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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

FIRST MEETING, 2026

Wednesday, 25th February, 2026

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 2:35 p.m.*

[THE SPEAKER, RT HON ALBAN
SUMANA KINGSFORD BAGBIN,
IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

The Speaker: Hon Members, on your behalf, I would acknowledge the presence of some visitors from some of our institutions. The first are students from the Sacred Heart Catholic Basic School. They are 51 in number and hail from the Essikadu-Ketan Constituency. They are led by the National Commission for Civic Education (NCCE) Assistant Director, Mavis Amoako-Hene.

Hon Members, on your behalf, I warmly welcome them to Parliament, their own House. They should take advantage of their presence here, not only to see and feel but to learn from assigned officials who will take you through a few things. Kindly resume your seats.

[Pupils of Sacred Heart Catholic Basic School were acknowledged.]

The second group come from the Axim Road Basic School in the Takoradi

Constituency. I hope the Member of Parliament (MP) knows the meaning of Takoradi. If he does not, I am here to be consulted. I will charge him and take some small fees, to tell him the meaning of Takoradi. They are led by the headmistress of the school, Mabel Mansang Frikpe. As I said, they are 53. You are also warmly welcome. My earlier statement applies equally to you. Kindly resume your seats.

[Pupils of Axim Road Basic School were acknowledged.]

The Speaker: We have the third group of students from the St Andrews School Complex, located in the Sekondi Constituency. They are 88 in number; that is quite large. They are led by the headmistress of the school, Emelia Agyefi Mensah. You are also warmly welcome. The same applies to you too. Please take advantage of your presence here to learn everything that you come across. Please resume your seats.

[Pupils of St Andrews School Complex were acknowledged.]

The Speaker: We have the fourth group coming from the Subin Constituency, they are called Havencrest Christian School. They are 44 in number, led by the proprietress of the school, Henrietta Adom-Nkansah. You are also warmly welcome. The same applies to you. Kindly resume your seats.

[Pupils of Havencrest Christian School were acknowledged.]

The Speaker: We have the last group of students, 91 in number and that is the highest. They are Be-Light International School coming from the Kpone-Katamanso Constituency. You are all invited to be the light. They are led by the headmaster in the person of Cyril Kwame Agbeh. You are also warmly welcome. This is your House; take full advantage of your presence here. Learn as much as you can and be better than this in future, so that Ghana will develop faster than we are doing. You are most welcome. Kindly resume your seats.

[Pupils of Be-Light International School were acknowledged.]

The Speaker: Hon Members, we now move to the item numbered 5, *Correction of Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT

The Speaker: We will start with the correction of *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 24th February, 2026.

Page 1...7—

Yes, Hon Member?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, on the page numbered 7, the item 3, the Hon MP for Karaga was in the Chamber yesterday, but he has been captured absent.

The Speaker: Is the MP for Karaga around?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, not at the moment.

The Speaker: Table Office, kindly take note of that. Cross-check and make sure it is properly captured. Yes, Hon Member?

2:45 p.m.

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, I am so grateful to you.

On the page numbered 7, item 5, titled “RECOGNITION OF VISITORS”, specifically item (c). That is on the next page, line two, after Daniel, the word should be “Nartey” not “Martey” They are from my constituency, so I have that on authority.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Table Office, kindly take note.

Page 8—

Hon Daniel Bessey Keshi?

Mr Daniel Bessey Keshi: Mr Speaker, thank you. Page 8, number 6, “Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* of the Twelfth”. The word “Twelfth”, should be spelt correctly.

So, it should be “Twelve”.

The Speaker: Hon Member, we are not spelling twelve. We are spelling twelfth, with the ‘th’. That is what we are spelling so it is correct.

Page 9—

Hon Vincent Ekow Assafuah?

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, on page 9, item 9,” STATEMENTS”.

When we read the last but one line, it is supposed to refer to the hospitals that have been initially stated. So, it would be proper if between “the” and “the hospitals”, we put the word “said” there. I will read for clarity;

“The Hon Minority Leader and Member of Parliament, Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin, made a Statement on the demise of 29-year-old Charles Amissah, a victim of a vehicle hit and run case who was refused emergency treatment by three public hospitals on Friday, 6th February, 2026, due to alleged non-availability of beds at the said hospitals.”

Thank you.

The Speaker: Hon Member, since the hospitals are not captured in the Statement, would it be proper to say at “the said hospitals” when we have not stated the hospitals? That is where you have the challenge. It is when you state the hospitals that you can now say, “the said hospitals.” But it has not been stated. If you want them to do so, they will capture those three hospitals, then we can conclude “said hospitals” but as it is now, that is the right rendition.

Yes, Hon Isaac Boamah-Nyarko?

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, page 9, still under 9(a), however, the second paragraph. I remember the decision of the House was to set up a committee to consider the facts relating to the case. So, I read, “facts relating to the case, including investigative reports from the three hospitals and the Ministry of Health on the matter.” However, the directive actually was to take the reports from Korle-Bu Teaching Hospital and the Ministry of Health. This is because with the reports we had, it was Korle-Bu Teaching Hospital that had established a committee to look into it, and not all the three hospitals. So, if the Table Office can refresh themselves on it. Otherwise, it would be like we have three different hospitals doing investigation into the matter, as well as the Ministry of Health. But from the reports we had yesterday, it was the Korle-Bu Teaching Hospital that indicated that they have set up a committee and then the Ministry had also set up another committee to look into the matter. So that would be mine.

The Speaker: First Deputy Speaker, you concluded that topic.

Mr First Deputy Speaker (Mr Bernard Ahiafor): Mr Speaker, that was not what happened. We were not to set a new committee. But we rather directed the Committee on Health to work with the committee that has been set, so that the Committee on Health can report to the House within three weeks.

The Speaker: First Deputy Speaker, you did not get the thrust of the issue he raised. He said what was before the

House was only a report that a committee had been set up at the Korle-Bu Teaching Hospital to investigate the matter and some action was being taken. But with the other two hospitals, there was no information before the House that they had also established committees to investigate the matter. But the report here has given the impression that the Speaker's Committee, the Committee on Health was to collect the reports from the three hospitals. But they do not have information before the House that the other two hospitals had also established committees to investigate the matter.

So, you could not have given a directive that they should collect reports from the three hospitals. The directive would be to collect reports from the Korle-Bu Teaching Hospital and the Ministry of Health and if there is any further directive to reach out to the other two hospitals for further information, and then deliberate upon them and report to the House, then that should be captured as what your directive extended to.

Mr Ahiafor: Mr Speaker, having listened to the Deputy Minister for Health, it does not appear that the committee is to investigate only Korle-Bu Teaching Hospital. They are going to undertake the investigation at the three hospitals. That was what we asked the Committee on Health to follow up with and report to the House.

The Speaker: The issue is still not clear from your response. When you read what is on the *Votes and Proceedings*, it says;

“The Rt Hon Speaker, taking cognisance of the Statement and comments raised thereon by Hon Members, *directed* the Committee on Health to consider the facts relating to the case, including investigative reports from the three hospitals and the Ministry of Health on the matter and report to the House.”

His point is that there was no information that the other two hospitals have caused an investigation into the matter. So, you cannot talk about including investigative reports from those two hospitals. What came before the House was investigation from Korle-Bu Teaching Hospital and the Ministry of Health? That is the issue that he raised. You did not tell the House that the other two hospitals have also established committees to investigate the matter. That is the issue he has raised.

So, we should not include that. If we want the committee to go further to conduct investigation into those two hospitals, then our committee will be doing that. Or they will have to submit information that they have also caused investigation into the matter. That was the issue he raised and,

2:55 p.m.

In any case, the directive was not from the Rt Hon Speaker; it was from the First Deputy Speaker. The Table should kindly take note of that. I then handed over the Chair to the First Deputy Speaker, who, at the conclusion of the comments, gave the directive. So, it was

not given by me; it was given by the First Deputy Speaker.

Yes, Deputy Majority Whip.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

When the Deputy Minister was contributing to the Statement, she mentioned that the Ministry has set up a committee to coordinate all the investigations that are going on with the three hospitals. So, the *Hansard* will capture what the Deputy Minister said.

The Speaker: Hon Member, we do not have a problem with the investigation by the Ministry. But what has been captured here is giving the impression that the other two hospitals have also set up an investigation into the matter at their hospitals. But that did not come before the House. That is what he is talking about. As for the Ministry's investigative report, it is properly captured. The report about Korle Bu is properly captured. But we do not have reports here from anybody. Nobody has made any statement that the other two hospitals also set up committees to investigate the matter. That is his reference.

So, Table, kindly capture it properly. Page 10.

Mr Richmond Edem Kofi Kpotosu: Mr Speaker, may I seek your dispensation to take us back to page 7? On recognition of visitors at the item numbered 5(a), I heard you loud and clear yesterday when you laid emphasis

on the name of the headteacher, Mrs Augustina Gyamera. The “Mrs” is conspicuously missing.

The Speaker: Table, kindly take note of that. It is Mrs Augustine Gyamera.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we are back to page 10.

Mr Assafuah: On the item numbered 10(b), the last paragraph, the “Hon First Deputy Speaker”, the “first” should be capital “F”, not small “f”. Also, the first paragraph on page 10, “The Hon First Deputy Speaker further directed that the committee present its report”. It has been captured as “presents”, that is, with “s”. I suggest that it should be without an “s”.

The Speaker: Yes, Table, he is right. Kindly take note of that.

Page 11— Is it page 10?

Ing Surv Maxwell Kwame Lukutor: Yes, Mr Speaker. On page 10, the item numbered 9 (b). I am not too sure that—

The Speaker: Hon Member, what did you say?

Ing Surv Lukutor: Page 10, the second paragraph, under the item numbered 9(b).

The name Dr Kwame Nkrumah, I am not too sure whether Osagyefo was added or not added. We now have other people with the name Dr Kwame Nkrumah, and Osagyefo is the

distinctive name that distinguishes him from all the others.

The Speaker: The other people with the name Dr Kwame Nkrumah, have they also been overthrown? *[Laughter]*

Ing Surv Lukutor: Mr Speaker, because we also have Osahen now, I think that it is just appropriate to add Osagyefo to his name.

The Speaker: Why do you leave the words before the name, and then you are talking about others? It is very clear there. The thing is talking about the anniversary of the overthrow of Dr Kwame Nkrumah. Then you say that there are other people with the name Dr Kwame Nkrumah. Have they also been overthrown?

Ing Surv Lukutor: I know of one Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah, who was overthrown. So if we are talking about the overthrow of some Kwame Nkrumah, I think that it is just fair that we add Osagyefo to it.

The Speaker: You cannot overthrow Osagyefo. If you add the name Osagyefo, you have to take away 'overthrow' because Osagyefo can never be overthrown.

Ing Surv Lukutor: But he was.

The Speaker: No. Do you know the meaning of Osagyefo? Yes, Hon Member.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, it is clear that he just wants to register that he is obeying the President's

directive of wearing a smock and a hat. The Minister for Finance is not wearing the smock and the hat; he is disobeying the President's order.

The Majority Leader is wearing a smock without a hat. Even you, Mr Speaker, obeyed the President's directive. Look at how beautifully you are dressed. Anybody will testify that you are properly dressed. The number three in this country is obeying the directive of the President. The Minister for Roads and Highways, seated next to the Minister for Finance, is properly dressed, but the Minister for Finance is not. I do not know whether Mr Isaac Adongo is attending an International Monetary Fund (IMF) meeting today, so he is not in a smock.

Mr Speaker, and the one who communicated the President's directive, Hon Felix, is not wearing a smock. I am not wearing the smock because the President said the majority of Ghanaians must wear a smock, but I am from the Minority, Mr Speaker. *[Laughter]* That is why I am not wearing it.

The Speaker: Majority Leader.

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I am a social democrat. Socialism dictates that we share. It would be greedy of me to keep the materials to myself and make a smock and a hat when others do not have smocks. So, I reserved the material for the hat for other poor people to also make their smocks. That is why I am wearing just the smock without the hat.

And if you, the Rt Hon Speaker, are wearing a hat, and I also come and sit here wearing a hat, what is the difference between Mr Speaker and me? He is the Speaker. When one goes to the palace and the chief is sitting in state and is wearing a smock and a hat, normally, what happens is that one removes their hat and kneels before the chief. So, I cannot come here, and the Speaker is wearing a hat, and I also wear a hat. It does not show respect to the Speaker.

But that is beside the point. My concern is that on the other Side of the House, I do not see anyone wearing a smock. I see northern Members of Parliament—I see the MP for Tolon, who, if he had worn a smock, would keep one citizen of Tolon employed. Will keep the weavers employed. Will keep the people making the smocks employed. As for Hon Alhassan, he is trying to play a game on us. He is not wearing a smock, but he is wearing a hat. So, he is keeping half employment for the North.

3:05 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I think we need to take the wearing of smocks seriously. It creates employment opportunities for our citizens and it shows that we are proud of our culture. Honestly speaking, I came out not wearing a smock; I had forgotten. I am sure for many people; they may have also forgotten. Fortunately, I have many in my office. It was Hon Habib Iddrisu who drew my attention to the fact that today is Wednesday and I am supposed to be wearing a smock. I quickly took off my coat and wore my smock. But it is

looking beautiful. I think I would probably look better today than if I had worn a suit.

So, let me thank Hon Habib Iddrisu for being an advocate for the wearing of smocks. Unfortunately, he does not practice what he preaches, and that is the problem. Last week, he raised this issue of smocks without wearing one. Today, he has raised it again, and he is still not wearing a smock. We will report him to the Yaa Naa. *[Laughter]*

The Speaker: Hon Members, can we continue now?

So, we move on to page 11...14—

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, on page numbered 14, item numbered 15, the very last paragraph, and if you would indulge me, I would like to read:

“The Hon First Deputy Speaker directed the Draftsperson to change the “three years” in Clause 33 (Clause 35(1), in the winnowing document) to “once every academic year”.”

Mr Speaker, the focus of my submission is on the second line, the very last word. I think we should delete and insert “winnowed document”. The document has already been winnowed, and not winnowing.

The Speaker: Is there any document that can be referred to as a “winnowed document”? Which document was winnowed? Look at your language. Can you refer to a document as “a winnowed document”?

Mr Afriyie: Well, Mr Speaker, I took motivation from the fact that when we were considering the Bill, that is the Legal Education Reform Bill, 2025, consistently, it is the case that the Hon First Deputy Speaker referred to the document we were using as the winnowed one. Indeed, for me, since, as I said earlier, it has been worked on already by the Winnowing Committee, that is why, in that context, I was thinking that referring to it again as “Winnowing” may not be appropriate. But whichever, we still learn from you. Thank you.

The Speaker: Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Yes, sorry, Mr Speaker. I was going to help him with the explanation, but he explained it well. I think there was a time during the Consideration Stage where we loosely described a Bill that had incorporated provisions that we had agreed on at winnowing. We agreed on certain provisions, and then we incorporated them into the Bill. So, we had two copies. The one document that we had incorporated, the clauses agreed to at winnowing, for ease of reference, and then the original Bill before us, so that each time that the Chairman of the Committee moved the Motion, he would also read the Bill that had the incorporated version, so that it would make for easy understanding and following by Hon Members.

So, during the process, we were loosely calling it the “Winnowed document”. But strictly speaking, it is not an appropriate rendition of what the Bill as corrected at winnowing is.

The Speaker: Well, from your explanation, then it could be captured as “in the winnowed Bill”, not “document”. You are referring specifically to the Bill that captured the Winnowing Committee’s Report amendments. So that is the “winnowed Bill”, and not “winnowed document” because “document” would refer to something else.

So, Table Office, kindly take note of that. Instead of “winnowing document”, you put “winnowed Bill”.

Hon Members, page 15—

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, page numbered 15, item numbered 5, “clause 50, Amendment proposed, subclause (2), *delete*.”

I think there is a drafting omission. We have to delete something, but there is nothing there. So, we may have to specify what is supposed to be deleted.

The Speaker: I think it is properly captured. What the amendment proposed was to *delete* subclause (2) of clause 50. So, when you move it, you say “clause 50, Amendment proposed, subclause (2), *delete*”. And the question was then put, and it is properly captured.

Hon Members, page 16...20?

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 24th February, 2026, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, I think my attention was drawn to item number 7 from the guidance of Leadership.

Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Yes, Mr Speaker. We could vary the order of Business so that we can go to Statements.

Mr Speaker, even though we have advertised Statements, I believe we have an understanding that it can be equally varied so that we can take a Statement from the Hon Minister for Finance on the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulated Policy, 2026 to 2028.

3:15 p.m.

I believe there has been adequate consultation at Conclave, even though there was a promise to also do certain things in response. But that consultation has taken place. So, Mr Speaker, we crave your indulgence that we vary order of Business and go to Statements.

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, with deference to the Hon Leader of the House, who is making application for order of Business to be varied, I think the Hon Leader does not need to make that application. If we are to reference Standing Order 67, Order 67(1) (t)—The Hon Leader will come with me, he is passionate about procedure. The Statement by the Minister takes precedence over other Statements by Members. He does not need to make an application for variation of order of Business, because it is rightly captured by 67(1)(t).

More to the point, last week, the Hon Leader, when he was presenting the Business Statement, put out a framework within which Statements are expected to be presented, the length of it, font size, pages, and all that. That Business Statement was adopted by this House. I am just seeking to know if it is the case that that framework that was adopted by this House is applicable to the Minister. It is supposed to be two pages. I am not preempting anything. I am just thinking aloud. So, if that framework is applicable to him, then he should be coming with two-page Statement, and the font size is also predefined. He should not defy that, because it is being adopted by this House.

Majority Leader, just be guided. The Minister, interestingly, is also a Member of Parliament, and he is the Leader of the House. Please communicate that position of the House which was adopted. He cannot go beyond two pages, and the font size has to be 12. *[Interruption]*

Yes, that was the position which was taken by this House, and he cannot defy that position. I respectfully submit.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I do agree with him that if we were to follow Order 67(1) strictly, that the Order of Business requires that the Minister takes precedence over the ordinary Member when it comes to a ministerial Statement. Mr Speaker, that is true, but we are dealing with a specific *Order Paper*. We are dealing with a specific *Order Paper* that did not advertise a place for ministerial Statements, but then went ahead and advertised a prioritisation of

Questions even before the Statements. Strictly speaking, going by this Order, if that is what is guiding the order of Business today, I needed to make the application. Mr Speaker, he does not oppose the application. That is the most important thing.

On the second issue of the length of the Statement, I recall that it was made clear that those guidelines applied to Hon Members, not ministerial Statements. I recall the Minority Chief Whip himself asking me a question, whether or not the guidelines also apply to Ministers. And I told the Hon Minority Chief Whip that I was not dictating the guidelines. The guidelines were agreed to at the Business Committee meeting. At the Business Committee meeting, there was no discussion of the application of the guidelines to Ministers. So, for me to take a decision without reference to the Business Committee would be inappropriate. So, the Business Committee has said nothing about ministerial Statements. The Business Committee was concerned about Statements by Hon Members. So, clearly, he knows why he is raising these issues. He knows that the issues have no bearing with this particular Statement. This Statement is not too long. It is reasonably long to communicate the policy, and I am sure that he will enjoy it. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we agree to disagree and disagree to agree. Our Side will not litigate further on this matter, but just to set the record straight. We cannot, as a House, set a framework for only Members of

Parliament. That would be lopsided. We set a framework in terms of Statement length, font size, and we leave out Members of Parliament who doubles as part of the Executive. That is a matter that we have to look at in whole so that we can address it. Maybe today we will permit the Hon Minister. Yes, today we will permit our Friend and we will allow him to make his Statement. But he should be reminded. Clearly, he is coming under Standing Order 91(2). So, the conditions inherent with 91(2)—Maybe let me read that to him, Mr Speaker, with your leave, I beg to quote:

“(2). A Minister of State may make a statement of government policy and the statement shall

(a) be limited to facts which are necessary to be made known to the House; and

(b) not contain matters that are likely to provoke debate.”

We are ready for him. As long as he is limiting his Statement to facts, there should be no issues. Mr Speaker, he should be guided. We are going to listen to him with rapt attention. So, he should live within the provisions of 91(2) and there will be peace. Mr Speaker, having said that, I think we are ready to listen to our Colleague. And he should stick to facts as I reiterated. I thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, avert your mind to Order 67(1)(r). Your first submission. Does it apply to that one too?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the rules are in your bosom. The interpretation of the rules is in your bosom pursuant to Standing Order 5 or so. Mr Speaker, it does not apply to you at all. It does not.

The Speaker: Because your submission was to the effect that Statements — you had prescribed how Statements were to be presented in the House: two pages, a font size and everything. But the Statements also include Statements by Mr Speaker. Were you prescribing how the Speaker is also to present his Statements? That one definitely is beyond your jurisdiction. *[Laughter]*

So, please, let us take it that we are aware of that. You know, Parliaments— *[Pause]*

Usually, we are faced with this problem of time management, and that is one of the reasons we want Statements to be precise and concise, not extending beyond two pages, the font size and all those things, and these Statements should be given to other Hon Members before they are read. It is because of that. In other Parliaments, they give time. One has two minutes and then, after the two minutes, the person is timed out, and the person just submits the Statement for it to be captured. Wherever a person reaches, they submit the Statement because nobody will hear them again. But we are not doing that here. That is why we are trying to use other ways of managing time on the Floor.

3:25 p.m.

So, let us take it that, that is applicable to Members. As you read yourself, Order 91 talks about it being limited to facts, which are necessary to be made known to the House, and not contain matters that are likely to provoke debate. That is what the Minister will have to work within. The Speaker has to admit Statements. The Statement was made available to me. I looked at the Standing Orders, scrutinised the Statement and I am of the view and took the decision, that the Statement is limited to facts, which are necessary to be made known to the House, and that it does not contain matters that are likely to provoke debate.

In fact, I scrutinised it. I even underlined words. I drew the Minister's attention to those things, and he was surprised I had time to read the Statement. So, be sure that there are no Statements there that will provoke debate at all. For that, I will arrest him before he makes those Statements. It is quite an important Statement, and it is very specific to the facts. There is no politics, or should I say, no partisanship in that Statement. That is my humble view. It needs the collective support of the House.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, we do not intend to litigate this matter further. But just for the record, Order 93(7) and (8), Mr Speaker, if you may permit me:

(7) The Speaker shall cause to be transmitted to the Clerk, State-

ments admitted to be made on a particular day, to be advertised on the Order Paper for the purpose of notice to Members.

- (8) The Clerk shall make available to Members, copies of admitted Statements.

I am only pleading that —

Mr Ayariga — *rose* —

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Leader, please, with respect. Mr Speaker, when my Colleague was on the Minority Side, any time Ministers attend upon the House —

The Speaker: Is he out of order?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, he is totally out of order. Order 91 speaks of “Statements by the Speaker and Minister”; listen carefully. They are in one category. Up to Order 91(6), nothing is said about copies being made available to be distributed to Members. Nothing is said. It is when we get to Order 93, which deals with Statement by Members, that we need first to submit the Statement to the Speaker, the Speaker has to admit it, minute it to the Clerk, and the Clerk should make copies available to Members. This is a Statement in a completely different category. So please, let us make the Statement and move on. He is totally out of order.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: The power to rule me out of order is not in the hands of the Leader. We have the Rt Hon Speaker, the most experienced Rt Hon Speaker presiding, and we have

confidence in him. He is a wise Speaker and will rule on these matters.

Whichever way the Majority Leader views it, the practice and the convention has been—When the Minister for Finance was Minority Leader, and he sat in this black seat, any time a sector Minister came to this House to make a policy Statement, copies were given to him. They were given prior notification of content. Members are not aware, so how are we to engage on this Statement? Our Ranking Members are ready to do justice to the Statement. Even Leadership are being kept in the dark.

It is interesting and very revealing that when the Minister for Finance was doing the haircut, he did not remember that there was a House of Parliament. For the haircut to the poor cocoa farmers, he did not consider it important to come to this House. Suddenly, he has found his way to this House. When our cocoa farmers were crying, he was busy in his office doing haircuts. On that, he did not find it prudent to come to this House to make a Statement. What is that? The farmers are looking for him. Sefwi Wiawso cocoa farmers are looking for him. Sankore cocoa farmers are looking for him. *Adɛɛ? Y’abrɛ wo.* To wit, we are tired. We are tired of the haircut. Mr Speaker, he was busy in his office engaging in haircut enterprise, reducing the price of cocoa anyhow. Now he has found his way to Parliament that he is coming to do what reserve? *Eii Ato! Eii Ato!*

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I can see clearly that once again, they are afraid of

the good news that the Minister for Finance is bringing to this House. Any time this Minister for Finance comes to this House, he is always a bearer of good news. Wonderful news such as the Gold Board which he enacted into law, which has stabilised the currency of this country. Such good news as the stability that the cedi is enjoying. Such good news as the inflation that has come down. They are afraid of the good news that he is bringing this time. They can do all that they are going to do, but he will make the Statement and he will bring the good news. Mr Speaker, we are waiting for the Statement.

The Speaker: Hon Members, I think at Conclave we discussed this matter and agreed that the Minister should make the Statement. We even went beyond that, and I am going to handle it in such a way that Members will have time to even debate the Statement which will now be a Motion. We will make it into a Motion and not conclude it today, but tomorrow you will get the opportunity. After Members have made comments on this Statement, we will make sure it comes in the form of a Motion because it is an important Government policy that has to be debated by this House and approved. It is not just going to go by Statement and that will be all.

So, we will capture all these concerns. As I said, Businesses are admitted by the Speaker, whether they are Statements or not. Whether they are Statements by a Minister or by a Member of Parliament, they have to be admitted by the Speaker; that is the first step. When they are admitted, then the

other Orders come in, whether it is Order 91 or Order 93. But as the Majority Leader said, in the case of Order 93, there is a specific Order which demands that copies of the Statement be made available to Members. But in the case of Order 91, there is no such Order that they should be made available to Members. If Members wish in future, we could do that, but as of now that is the rule and we will go by that.

So, I will allow the Minister to make the Statement and I will give the opportunity for Members to make comments. We will make copies available to Members and, in fact, I will even refer it to the Finance Committee. Then they can come tomorrow by a Motion for us to now debate it. Yes, I will do so. Yes, Minority Leader, do you want to say something?

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, rightly so. Thank you for giving me the opportunity to make a statement. Mr Speaker, you know the Minister for Finance was once upon a time a Minority Leader. There are certain aspects of him that I want to put notice to him on. At the dispatch box, there is no point of order against him, so he should stick to his Statement. *[Laughter]* He should not abuse the opportunity that Mr Speaker will give him. He should stick to just the Statement he brought, which was prepared. He should not be throwing jabs because we will not have the opportunity—Mr Speaker, I know him. He has notoriety for running away with certain jabs.

He promised GH¢6,000 per bag of cocoa but he has reduced it to GH¢2,500 per bag. He chose to announce it in his office.

3:35 p.m.

He did not come to Parliament. He should go and do his Statement, but he should not say anything outside of his Statement.

Mr Speaker, thank you so much. Let him comply.

The Speaker: Hon Members, leave that one to me. I will handle it. It is good that you have drawn my attention. Hon Minister, please, the House is ready to listen to you.

STATEMENT

Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP) 2026 – 2028

Minister for Finance (Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson) (MP): Mr Speaker, permit me to extend my profound gratitude to you and to Hon Members of this House for the opportunity to present this important Policy Statement of the Government and country.

Mr Speaker, Ghana achieved a decisive macroeconomic turnaround in 2025, following the 2022-2023 economic crisis by the end of 2025. Mr Speaker, real Gross Domestic Product (GDP) growth averaged 6.1 per cent in the first three quarters of 2025. Inflation declined sharply from 23.8 per cent in

2024 to 5.4 per cent, and further down to 3.8 per cent in January 2026. Mr Speaker, interest rate fell sharply, with the 91-day Treasury bill dropping from 27.7 per cent at the end of 2024 to 11.1 per cent in December, and further down to 6.4 per cent in February 2026. The primary balance on a commitment basis improved significantly, from a deficit of 3 per cent in 2024 to a surplus of 2.6 per cent in the year 2025.

Mr Speaker, public debt declined sharply from 61.8 per cent of GDP in 2024 to 45.3 per cent of GDP in 2025. The current account posted a surplus of US\$9.1 billion, up from US\$1.5 billion in 2024. Mr Speaker, the cedi appreciated by 40.7 per cent against the US dollar, 30.9 per cent against the British pound, and 24 per cent against the Euro. The gross international reserves also increased to US\$13.8 billion, representing 5.7 months of import cover from US\$8.9 billion, equivalent to four months of import cover.

Mr Speaker, the current gross international reserves level is above the traditional reserve benchmark of three months of import cover. This is, however, not sufficient to provide adequate self-insurance against disruptive economic shocks and its impact on exchange rates, like the historical depreciation of the currency in the years 2022 and 2023.

To strengthen Ghana's resilience to economic shocks, Cabinet has approved the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy. The Policy represents Ghana's strategic plan to

strengthen external resilience by increasing the nation's international reserve equivalent of 15 months of import cover by the end of 2028. Mr Speaker, this Policy is anchored on the objectives of the Ghana Gold Board Act, 2025 (Act 1140), which mandates the Ghana GoldBod to generate foreign exchange for the country and support gold reserves accumulation by the Bank of Ghana. The Policy is also informed by the country's cycle of economic downturns, recent macroeconomic development, global risk assessment, and Ghana's long-term economic transformation agenda.

Mr Speaker, historically, Ghana has relied heavily on inflows from gold, cocoa, and crude oil exports to build international reserves. However, over the last decade, the country has relied largely on costly swaps, sales and buybacks, and other short-term facilities, as well as Eurobond borrowings to build international reserves, resulting in significant debt service obligations to the people of Ghana. Mr Speaker, this development in the last decade led to the unsustainable debt situation in 2022, the resultant debt default and restructuring, haircut, and subsequent requests for International Monetary Fund (IMF) supported Extended Credit Facility (ECF) programme.

Mr Speaker, despite cocoa's historical importance, its contribution to sustainable foreign exchange stability has been undermined by price volatility, low production, climate risk, and limited value addition. Crude oil, which initially promised to provide fiscal relief and

balance of payment support, is now declining very fast due to lack of investment in the last eight years and waning investor confidence, resulting in six years of consistent oil output decline.

Mr Speaker, despite the progress made in 2025, growing global uncertainties make Ghana vulnerable to external financing volatilities, commodity price cycles, global geopolitical tensions, climate-related disruptions, and regional security risk. These have simultaneously lifted gold prices to a historic high and provided an opportunity for Ghana to build reserves to secure the country's external sector against any major shock, to strengthen Ghana's first line of defense.

Mr Speaker, given these uncertainties, the conventional threshold of three months of import cover is no longer adequate for any country. Government therefore seeks to accumulate a strategic buffer beyond the conventional reserve adequacy levels and build an economic war chest of 15 months of import cover by the end of 2028. This is to safeguard macroeconomic stability, break the cycle of economic downturns, sustain confidence in the currency, and improve investor confidence. Also, to reduce exposure to external shocks and support the long-term economic transformation of our dear country.

Mr Speaker, the objective of this Policy is to build reserves to 15 months of import cover to support Ghana's long-term economic transformation without compromising economic stability. Historically, this strategy is not new

globally. After the 1997 Asian financial crisis, the most affected countries embarked on aggressive foreign exchange reserve accumulation as a key policy response. This was driven largely by a desire for self-insurance against future sudden capital reversals and crisis following the traumatic experience of relying on IMF bailout, which came with some strict conditionalities.

Mr Speaker, this helped these economies far better during the later shocks like the 2008 global financial crisis without depleting their external reserves. A diagnosis of Ghana's reserve trajectory shows a pattern of episodic accumulation linked to opportunistic external borrowing and seasonal cocoa outflows, followed by downturns and drawdowns to meet external obligations. Mr Speaker, clearly you could see from the chart below that over the years government of Ghana has been building reserves largely from Eurobond borrowings and borrowing from the IMF over the last few years.

Mr Speaker, from a reserve position of 5.4 months of import cover in 2021, following a Eurobond issuance of US\$3 billion, reserves sharply declined to a low of under 2.3 months of import cover in September 2023, thereby triggering the depreciation of our currency. The depreciation reflected a strain on external buffers in the face of constrained financial options, capital outflows, heightened macroeconomic pressures, and the need to meet critical foreign exchange obligations such as debt repayment.

Mr Speaker, global gold prices have reached unprecedented levels driven by heightened international risk, sustained accumulation by central banks, and strong safe-haven demand.

3:45 p.m.

These developments significantly bolstered export earnings and strengthened external buffers for gold-producing economies, including Ghana.

Mr Speaker, with prices far exceeding their long-term historical averages, gold has emerged as the most reliable and immediate instrument for accelerating reserve accumulation without increasing public debt or introducing distortions in domestic market. Projections from major international financial institutions indicate that gold prices are likely to remain elevated and favourable over the medium term, underscoring the resilience and persistence of the current price cycle.

Mr Speaker, the outlook for gold prices provided a solid foundation for policies that strengthen external buffers, reduce vulnerability to external shock, and support long-term financial stability of Ghana. Harnessing this momentum will be essential to building a more robust and resilient reserve management framework capable of withstanding future global volatilities. The sustained elevation in global gold price presents a strategic opportunity for gold-producing countries to further enhance their reserve-build-up framework, reinforce their external position, and enhance macroeconomic resilience.

Mr Speaker, major gold-producing countries and central banks are capitalising on historical high gold prices by increasing production, export, and official purchases to strengthen their external buffers. China, the world's largest producer of gold, continues to expand its domestic refinery capacity and use gold both as a key export and as a strategic reserve asset for diversification. Similarly, Russia has leverage on this elevated price environment to boost gold export, export revenues, and channel part of the proceeds into reserve accumulation, using gold as a shock absorber against financial sanctions and global volatility. Australia benefited from high prices through stronger export receipts, improved terms of trade, and higher fiscal and external surplus, which indirectly support reserve strength.

Mr Speaker, across these countries, elevated gold prices are being deliberately used to enhance the foreign exchange inflows, support balance of payment, resilience, and reinforce reserve position amid heightened global uncertainty. This current gold price surge presents a timely opportunity for Ghana to leverage the country's gold resources to accelerate reserve accumulation and reinforce long-term external resilience for our country.

Mr Speaker, the primary objective of the Ghana National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP) is to increase Ghana's international reserve to 15 months of import cover by the end of 2028 to support long-term structural transformation while safeguarding the

macroeconomic stability. To achieve this, the following intermediate targets are set. First is to achieve a minimum of 8.6 months of import cover by end of this year, 2026. Second, to exceed 11.8 months by end of 2027. And third, to reach 15 months of import cover by end of 2028.

Mr Speaker, these milestones will be reviewed annually based on realised imports, prices, production volumes, and financing conditions. Our gross international reserves at 5.7 months of import cover at the end of 2025, the gap to achieve the target of 15 months of import cover is 9.3 months of import cover. This implies an average annual accumulation of 3.1 months of import cover over the next three years. In 2025, Ghana accumulated additional gross international reserves of 1.6 months of import cover. This provides momentum for the country, but must be accelerated to achieve an average of 3.1 months of import cover in the shortest possible time.

Mr Speaker, to secure the target after netting out debt service, forex operations, energy sector payment, and statutory outflows, the strategy requires an average of US\$9.5 billion annual additions to the country's gross international reserves. To achieve the reserve accumulation target, the GANRAP has set an operational weekly gold purchase target of about three tonnes per week. At three tonnes per week and a price of US\$5,000 per ounce, gross receipts are projected at approximately US\$25.28 billion annually.

Mr Speaker, Ghana's strategy for the acquisition of three tonnes of gold per week is in two folds. The first is the Ghana Gold Board to acquire up to 2.4 tonnes of gold per week from artisanal small-scale mining sector. The Ministry of Finance will be making budgetary allocation to the Ghana Gold Board to achieve the objectives. Secondly, the Ministry of Land and Natural Resources is to invoke the preemption right under section 3(d) of the Ghana Gold Board Act, 2025 (Act 1140), and section 7 of the Minerals and Mining Act, 2006 (Act 703), to purchase a minimum of 0.5 tonnes of gold per week from large-scale gold mines.

Mr Speaker, the Bank of Ghana will purchase the gold acquired from large-scale mining sector. The gold purchased under section 3(d) of the Gold Board Act and section 7 of the Minerals and Mining Act 2006 shall only be sold by the central bank subject to prior approval of Cabinet and Parliament. Mr Speaker, the following measures will be implemented in the short to medium term.

A change in the current acquisition arrangement of the 20 per cent large-scale gold output by the Bank of Ghana will be implemented in the short term. First, to ensure compliance by the large-scale mining companies, Government shall establish an interagency committee, co-chaired by the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources and the Minister for Finance with membership from the Governor of the Bank of Ghana and the Chief Executive Officer of the Minerals Commission and the Ghana Gold Board. The Ministry of Lands and Natural

Resources shall invoke the preemption right under section 3(d) of the Ghana Gold Board Act to purchase a minimum of 20 per cent of large-scale gold output, which translates to a minimum of 0.57 tonnes of gold per week.

Mr Speaker, the gold acquired from the large-scale mining sector shall strictly be in the form of doré and processed in Ghana to promote local value addition. The transaction shall be in Ghana cedis only at a prevailing interbank exchange rate and at a discount to be determined by the parties. The applicable discount rate shall be determined based on volume between the Government of Ghana and the large-scale mining companies. the gold purchased in doré under this new acquisition arrangement shall be refined by local gold refineries, shipped to LBMA refineries for melting, bar casting and stamping and added to the fiscal gold reserves of the country. This gold shall only be sold by the central bank, subject to prior approval of Cabinet and Parliament. These measures will ensure strict enforcement of commitment by large-scale mining firms, local value retention, transparency, good governance and acquisition cost reduction while supporting local gold refineries to attain an LBMA certification and standards.

Mr Speaker, the Ghana Gold Board as the national assayer is strategically positioned to enforce this newly proposed acquisition arrangement as it maintains field offices in gold rooms of all large-scale mining firms and assays samples from large-scale gold output

before export. The Ghana Gold Board has successfully piloted this new acquisition arrangement with nine large-scale mining firms in the last six months. The Ghana Gold Board will put in place a strategy to efficiently mop adequate volumes of artisanal small-scale mining (ASM) gold output, minimum of 2.45 tonnes weekly, through official channels to generate adequate foreign exchange for the country.

3:55 p.m.

Mr Speaker, over the next three (3) years, the Ghana Gold Board aims to mop up about 127 tonnes of ASM gold per annum. This, at current price levels, will generate over US\$20 billion in foreign exchange for the country annually.

Mr Speaker, to achieve this objective in an efficient manner the following policy measures will be implemented in the Artisanal and Small-Scale Mining (ASM) sector:

- The Ghana Gold Board shall arrange enough funds to acquire about 3 to 4 weeks of gold and ensure continuous market participation.
- The Ghana Gold Board will assume full responsibility for the signing of off-take agreements and the sale of all ASM gold it procures effective March 2026. This will ensure effective end-to-end trading with off-takers and mitigate trading losses while

pursuing trading gains for the country.

- The Ghana Gold Board shall deploy effective gold-backed derivative trading programmes and hedging strategies to mitigate market risk.
- To disincentivise smuggling and ensure that adequate volumes of ASM gold are purchased, the Ghana Gold Board may employ price incentives through spot world market price purchases and bonuses for licensed miners.
- Mr Speaker, in the medium term, the Ghana Gold Board will promote ASM formalisation, value-chain traceability and local gold refining to further reduce cost while maximising returns from gold exports in a sustainable manner.
- Mr Speaker, the Bank of Ghana and the Ghana Gold Board shall sign an agreement which mandates the Ghana Gold Board to sell the foreign exchange accrued under this policy to the Bank of Ghana only, at a cost determined by the two parties.
- The Ghana Gold Board is mandated to employ trading reforms to reduce its operating cost.
- The Ghana Gold Board to facilitate the establishment of modern

LBMA-compliant processing plants in partnership with private investors to optimise recovery, particularly in the ASM sector and promote sustainability.

- Special efforts in the form of a nationwide water-body cleansing campaign within designated mining areas will be undertaken by the Ghana Armed Forces.
- Mr Speaker, the National Anti-Illegal Mining Operations Secretariat (NAIMOS) shall intensify their activities against illegal mining, especially illegal mining activities in water bodies and forest reserves.
- The Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources and the Ghana Gold Board shall support and scale-up sustainability initiatives such as land reclamation.

Other Reserve Boosting Policy Measures

Mr Speaker, Government will deepen structural reforms that expand foreign exchange inflows while reducing persistent FX outflows. Key focus areas include:

- Enhancement of Non-Traditional Exports (NTEs): Scaling up cashew, shea, rubber, and processed agricultural exports;
- Cocoa Sector Recovery: Boosting productivity, rehabilitating diseased farms, and stabilising market access;

- Implementation of the National Policy on Integrated Oil Palm Development: Develop 100,000 hectares of new oil palm plantations to ensure self-sufficiency and accumulate foreign exchange;
- Remittance Mobilisation: Strengthening digital financial systems to capture a larger share of diaspora inflows;
- Developing New Oil Fields: Accelerating new field developments such as Pecan, to bolster production;
- Energy Sector FX Savings: Mr Speaker, historically, Ghana has spent approximately \$3.0 billion annually to cover energy sector shortfalls and IPP payments.
- This continuous drain acted as a “leaky bucket” for foreign exchange, forcing the Bank of Ghana to divert liquid reserves to meet fuel and power obligations.
- The implementation of the Gas-to-Power Transformation Policy will significantly conserve the country’s foreign exchange reserves, making way for sustainable reserve accumulation.
- The Gas-to-Power Policy measures include:
 - i. construction of a state-owned 1,200MW power plant;

- ii. construction of a second gas processing plant (GPP2); and
- iii. revamping the oil & gas sector to attract investment into the upstream petroleum sector.

- Mr Speaker, most importantly, maintaining fiscal discipline (primary surplus) is critical to slowdown the pace of foreign exchange reserves depletion.

Cost-Benefit Analysis of the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP)

Costs

Mr Speaker, in the last 8 years, the Bank of Ghana has relied on swaps, sale and buy-backs (SBBs) and other short-term facilities to build reserves. This has been done at a very high cost.

In 2022, 2023 and 2024, the Bank of Ghana accumulated reserves of about US\$3 billion, US\$2 billion and US\$650 million at a cost of US\$615 million, US\$476 million, and US\$67 million, respectively through Swaps and Sale and Buy-backs.

Mr Speaker, in those three years, from 2022 to 2024, the Bank of Ghana accumulated reserves of US\$5.65 billion from Swaps and Sale and Buy-backs at a cost of US\$1.16 billion in interest payments only.

The Bank of Ghana also borrowed from international commercial banks

such as JP Morgan, Standard Chartered Bank, and Citi Bank to the tune of US\$2.0 billion between 2018 and 2021 at a cost of US\$182 million.

In 2017, Government relied on the inflows from the issuance of a US\$2.25 billion bond from Franklin Templeton to support reserve build-up.

Mr Speaker, the inflow of US\$2.25 billion from Franklin Templeton to partake in the domestic bond issuance of early 2017, cost the nation about GH¢7.3 billion in interest payments alone from 2017 to 2022.

Between 2018 and 2021, Ghana again relied heavily on external borrowings to support reserve build-up.

A total of about US\$11.025 billion was borrowed by Government from the Eurobond market during the period. These came at a very high cost, ranging between 7.6 per cent and 9.6 per cent per annum.

Mr Speaker, the issuance of the US\$11.025 billion of Eurobonds from 2018 to 2021, to support reserve build up, costed Ghana the following:

- a. US\$81.26 million in 2018;
- b. US\$287.58 million in 2019;
- c. US\$524.68 million in 2020;
- d. US\$740.77 million in 2021; and
- e. US\$844.83 million in 2022.

In total, the Eurobond borrowings between 2018 and 2021 to support reserve build-up costed the taxpayer about US\$2.5 billion in interest payments alone.

It should be noted that Ghana is still servicing these debts, following the end-2022 debt default.

In 2026 alone, Ghana is required to pay US\$1.5 billion in debt service to Eurobond holders.

Mr Speaker, at the peak of the 2022 economic crises, Ghana lost access to the International Capital Market and was in dire need of foreign exchange.

Government once again resorted to expensive borrowing of €200 million, US\$196.58 million and US\$350 million from Afri-Exim Bank at an all-in cost rate of 6.49 per cent and 9.55 per cent, and 9.33 per cent per annum respectively, to support reserve build-up.

Evidently, all these borrowings from 2017-2022 were not enough to stabilise the Ghana Cedi leading to depletion of the reserves to unprecedented levels and significant depreciation of the cedi.

It is obvious that borrowing to support reserves accumulation is unsustainable and leads to high debt distress and debt overhung.

4:05 p.m.

Mr Speaker, between 2017 and 2024, the Bank of Ghana and the Ministry of Finance collectively borrowed to the

tune of US\$21.7 billion to support reserve build-up at an interest cost of US\$3.84 billion and GH¢7.3 billion through Franklin Templeton interest payment.

Mr Speaker, if Government of Ghana had borrowed US\$ 10 billion at the 2025 yield of 8 per cent, the cost to the nation would have been US\$800 million in just one year. The cost of accumulation reserves through Ghana Gold Board in the year 2025, was significantly lower than the cost of Ghana's 2022/2023 swaps and sale in buybacks. The evidence is so clear.

Mr Speaker, in addition to the comparable lower costs of the Ghana Gold Board model, the activities of the Ghana Gold Board have been instrumental in restoring macroeconomic stability in Ghana. In 2025, some of the benefits include the following; significant international reserve accumulation, historic appreciation of the Ghanaian cedi, significant reduction in inflation, significant improvement in their sustainability and significant savings in the servicing of government external obligation, interest costs, amortisation payment and IPP costs.

Mr Speaker, these macroeconomic gains have delivered meaningful relief to households and businesses through the reduction in fuel prices, food prices, cost of doing business and cost of living. Government will adopt proactive approach to risk management under the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy.

Price risk will be mitigated through hedging mechanism and complemented by other trading models. Production risk will be addressed by modernising mining, processing technology and diversifying production site.

Mr Speaker, governance risk will be mitigated through independent audits and enhanced transparency. Environmental and social risk will be addressed through intensified enforcement of anti-illegal mining laws, targeted reclamation, alternative livelihood programmes and community engagement programmes.

Mr Speaker, this structured approach aimed to transform mining from a volatile revenue source into a stable, transparent, socially and environmentally responsible pillar for macroeconomic stability.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, this reserve accumulation policy provides a clear, actionable and forward-looking framework to enhance Ghana's external resilience. Ghana is positioned to achieve and sustain reserve equivalent to 15 months of import cover by end 2028. This will be the first time ever in the history of Ghana. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, for emphasis, Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah inherited reserves of 11 months of import cover. We strive to achieve 15 months of import cover by 2028. *[Hear! Hear!]* Government remains committed to executing this policy with discipline, transparency and national consensus. The long-term objective is clear; build an economic war

chest to withstand global economic shocks, to secure macroeconomic stability, sustain the economic gains made, improve the standard of living of Ghanaians and build lasting national prosperity for our future generation.

Mr Speaker, on this historic occasion, I call on this august House to consider and approve Ghana's first national Policy, deliberately designed to build external reserves and secure the future of our country.

Mr Speaker, I so submit.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we have listened to the Statement by the Minister for Finance. But the Statement has gone beyond the ambit of Statements. It ended by calling on the House to consider and approve Ghana's first national Policy deliberately designed to build external reserves and secure the future of our country. If we have to approve, then it has to be a Motion. So, the Statement has been made and I will take some comments. But I will have to refer it to the appropriate Committee, that is the Finance Committee, to come by way of a Motion, which will be debated and then we can give our approval.

Usually, we do not give approval to Statements; we make comments. But these are matters on which Members may want to make inputs. So, it goes beyond that. You have to make inputs and give your verdict by approving or

disapproving. That means that, it has to come by Motion.

So, today, we would take a few comments, and in consultation with Leaders, it has been decided that we would take four contributors from each Side of the House. Three Members and one Leader per each Side of the House. Since the Minister for Finance is from the Majority Side and he has presented the Statement, we would take the first comments from the Minority Side.

Therefore, if I am to go by the list that has been given to me and according to precedence, it will be Dr Gideon Boako. I am told you are limited to a five minutes commentary. The five minutes starts from now.

Dr Gideon Boako (NPP — Tano North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity granted me to comment on the Statement made by the Minister for Finance on the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy.

Mr Speaker, I have listened to the Minister, the reference to the Finance Committee and until then, we would wait. But before then, I wish to make these preliminary comments. Listening to the Minister for Finance, it is important that we agree that where Ghana has got to needs to accumulate enough reserves to anchor our currency and protect safeguards for the economy.

The Minister for Finance has stated that this is the first time Ghana is having such a bold policy. I wish to differ in opinion that this whole policy hinges on

gold and it is important that we stress that the policy to accumulate gold, to shore up our currency and provide other benefits to the economy, is not the first time we are having such a policy.

In fact, as the Minister is aware, somewhere in 2021/2022, the Bank of Ghana embarked on the Domestic Gold Purchase Programme and the Gold for Reserves under the leadership of the former Vice President, Dr Mahamudu Bawumia. [*Hear! Hear!*] It is this policy that has anchored our currency to today. It is important that today this Government has realised the need to increase our good reserves and therefore is coming to Parliament with this Policy. This is how we should govern.

Mr Speaker, I wish to state that I would have loved that when it came to the point of having “cocoa haircuts” for cocoa farmers, the same policy should have come to Parliament for us to debate on as the Minister is doing today.

Mr Speaker, it is an undeniable fact that Ghana holds a strategic position in gold production in the world and Africa. Despite this, the level of Ghana's gold holdings is quite anaemic relative to the total holdings institute. Therefore, it is important that as a country, we make steps to accumulate more gold.

Mr Speaker, if this is the position of Government and rightly so, as presented by the Minister for Finance, it begs the question, why this Government decided to sell portions of the gold accumulated that they inherited for this country?

Mr Speaker, before the assumption of this Government, we had increased Ghana's gold reserves from eight tonnes to 32 tonnes and the Government came in to increase it to 38 tonnes. But today as we speak, half of our good reserves have been sold by this Government. If the policy intention of Government is to accumulate more gold to support the economy, why did the Government decide to sell good that was already existing before they came into power?

4:15 p.m.

I heard the argument that we needed to sell that gold because we needed liquidity in forex. Yes, it is important that foreign exchange provides liquidity for the economy, but gold reserves also provide monetary solidity and market confidence. We need both as a country in order to thrive in the globally changing economic system. That is why we from the Minority Side, support any attempt by Government to shore up our currency, to shore up our economy with gold reserves. Mr Speaker, it is important.

What is missing from the Minister's presentation is the lack of clarity as to whether or not we are moving 100 per cent to gold reserves or we are moving 100 per cent to foreign exchange reserves or we are having a balancing mix. It is important that we manage our gold accumulation within a certain composition mix ratio such that we have enough foreign exchange in terms of fiat currency for liquidity while also holding gold reserves. It is not clear from the Minister's policy presentation whether or not we are moving straightly to 100 per

cent accumulation of gold or 100 per cent accumulation of forex reserves or if we are having a balancing of the two. Gold reserves are not the same as foreign exchange reserves, although gold reserves can be liquidated to get foreign exchange. So, we need to have clarity on that.

Mr Speaker, it is also important to know from the Minister's presentation, and that is lacking, how we intend to finance the purchase of this gold. Gold Board came into being by changing the name from Precious Minerals Marketing Company (PMMC) to Gold Board with an Act. The Minister had told this Parliament that the Government of Ghana was going to finance Gold Board. We never saw any action in that regard, although there were budgetary provisions for that. The Minister never acted on that, only to realise that the Bank of Ghana was rather pumping money to support Gold Board. But the Minister talks about the achievement that has been made in the foreign exchange market by way of the stability of the cedi. That is fantastic. But it is important for the Minister to note that it does not make economic sense to pump over US\$10 billion in cedi foreign exchange intervention and only reduce the rate from 14 to about 11 to 12, when in the past, under the previous government, the rate was reduced from 16 to 14 without a US\$10 billion intervention in the economy —

The Speaker: Thank you. You have done very well with your comments. We would move on to the other Side and we would listen to Hon Isaac Adongo.

4:20 p.m. — [HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE CHAIR]

Mr Isaac Adongo (NDC—Bolgatanga Central): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity. I would like to thank the Minister for Finance for his forthrightness and his love for our country, and to thank His Excellency the President and the Cabinet of the Government for thinking about the future of our country and trying to address one of the most significant challenges that we have faced over the last years. Of course, I am happy that my Colleagues have demonstrated the need to support this policy, except to say that they must share in the glory.

Mr Speaker, at the time we were going to the International Monetary Fund (IMF) in 2022, Ghana's reserve could only support 0.8 months, less than two weeks of import cover. Yet, somebody said he started gold purchase programme and gold for reserves, but ended up without reserves and had to go to the IMF because after printing a lot of cedis, they struggled to externalise the cedis to pay external obligations and needed now to go and tell the world that they cannot pay. But we want people to understand that nobody pumped US\$10 billion into the economy. We inherited a reserve of US\$8 billion. As we speak, we ended the year 2025 with a reserve position of US\$13 billion. How do you pump US\$10 billion out of US\$8 billion and end the year with US\$13 billion? So, clearly, nobody pumped US\$10 billion into the economy and that continuous peddling of falsehood will not become

the truth. The truth is that we took office with a reserve of US\$8 billion, we have added US\$5 billion to push it to US\$13 billion. The US\$10 billion that financed the economy is an intermediation of the economy's own generation of forex. It is not money sitting at Bank of Ghana, which we call people and pump the money for them. So, please, that has to disappear.

Mr Speaker, my Colleague also made a very important Statement that I would want to associate with. It is important that we understand that this is going to cost a lot of money and as a country, we must think around how to finance all these ambitious projects that we intend to embark on. The emphasis is to convert cedi resources into forex resources. Certainly, when we undertake that, it also means that with the reserve that we are building, Ghanaians are going to work to produce the gold. Ghanaians are now going to get a lot of money, so definitely, the central bank must now incur the cost of mopping up the excess liquidity. As a country, we must engage in the conversation to share the cost of mopping up that excess liquidity so that it does not sit entirely in the books of the central bank in an attempt to solve a major problem for which our tool is to assist with the central bank.

Mr Speaker, we also have to understand that inbuilt in this exercise is the need to have a robust risk management system. A couple of years back, in 1999, for those of you who are old enough, you would have heard that the Bank of England offloaded a stock of gold. Immediately, gold prices collapsed,

and our own gold share at Ashanti Goldfields became a problem because the shares at Ashanti Goldfields plummeted. As a result, we had to sell the gold shares to Ashanti Gold and it was because we had hedged our gold into the future and were being called upon to make margin costs of about US\$250 million which Goldfields did not have. So, we need to understand that it is not enough to pile up gold at the Bank of Ghana that will be facing risk when, in fact, it is the forex that we need. So, we need to assess how much of gold we need to keep *vis-a-vis* the forex that we have. So, when the central bank decided to liquidate about 22 per cent of gold resources at the bank, it was precisely to manage the risk. That is why we did not see a fall in the reserve, but rather an increase in the reserve to US\$13 billion. Do we want to keep gold alone so that when gold prices plummet, then all our reserves disappear? We must have a risk management tool that allows us to balance what we need to keep and our peers across the world were doing an average of 18 to 22 per cent of their reserve in gold.

Mr Speaker, therefore, we decided to also follow the same footsteps by making sure that we liquidate the excess gold so that we are within the 20 to 22 per cent of gold reserve in our portfolio. That was what was done. It is not that —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. Your microphone is off. It is now the turn of Hon Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo, you have five minutes, beginning from now.

Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo (NPP — Manso Nkwanta): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to comment on the Statement made by the Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, I listened carefully to the Minister for Finance, and I know he is following the same trend that we know, that the economy is doing well, macroeconomic indicators are looking good. The little I would require of our Minister for Finance is that whenever he is giving such indicators, he should please let us know what is happening across the world or the globe. Let us know what is happening in our subregion so that we can make some inference and do some comparisons.

Mr Speaker, it is not just Ghana. The trends that we are seeing are not just Ghana. I had the opportunity to be in Monrovia, where we had a high-level discussion on the convergence to have the eco-coming upstream end of next year. We could see that within the subregion, all the macroeconomic metrics that we are patting ourselves on the back for, are equally doing well. But then we ask ourselves, even in Ghana, what really are the middle movers that are really supporting the macroeconomic indicators that our Minister for Finance spoke about?

4:25 p.m. —

Mr Speaker, we are touting ourselves that we want to build reserves with the gold. If they want to make GoldBod a better institution, what they are doing now is introducing risks. If we look at the

structure now, we have one institution at the very top called the Bawa Rock Company Limited. It is the only institution aggregating all the gold we are getting from this country.

Mr Speaker, this is a significant risk to this country because Bawa Rock Company Limited has got the security or guarantee to underwrite this gold. But let us ask ourselves why we would allow just one company to bear such significant risk? It is just too much risk for one company to bear. Now we want to build significant reserves, and we have this company that has been exposed so much that any trigger on the guarantee that it is producing will send us flat, and this policy that we are bringing across will just flop completely.

So, Mr Speaker, I would rather advise that we look at managing the risk of GoldBod to ensure that the entity we are relying on to help us build the reserves we are trying to boost is run well and that the risk is well managed.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Member.

I will give the floor to Hon Felix Kwakye Ofori.

Mr Felix Kwakye Ofori (NDC — Abura-Asebu-Kwamankese): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment briefly on the presentation made by the Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, this has to go down as one of the most forward-looking economic policies envisaged by any government because we do know that the Ghanaian economy, for many decades prior to last year, had been undermined significantly by challenges with the extent of our reserves and the implications that it has on the depreciation of our currencies. Indeed, as the Minister highlighted in his Statement, previous governments have attempted to address our forex concerns through expensive borrowing, and he indeed showed that in the eight-year period that our Friends on the other Side stayed in government, they had to cough out US\$3.4 billion and GH¢7.3 billion in order to borrow up to US\$21.4 billion to shore up our reserves and protect our currency.

Even then, our currency suffered a catastrophic decline, which then imposed severe hardships and suffering on the people of Ghana. It meant that a succeeding government was going to have to toe a different line in order to achieve the objective of having significant reserves to protect our currency, and this Government has proven resourceful in coming up with this arrangement to ensure that we overcome this perennial difficulty. Our Friends have a penchant for being quick to claim credit for the successes chalked in the last year in terms of the gains made by the Ghana cedi. They claim it is a product of some policy initiative implemented by their now flagbearer and former chairperson of the Economic Management Team.

Mr Speaker, when it suits them, in one breath, they say that he had absolutely nothing to do with economic management and that it was the responsibility of somebody else to manage the economy and then in another breath, they insist that the same man who had nothing to do with the economy was able to single-handedly impose a gold for reserve policy on the government. So, they have to decide where they stand. Was the man in charge of the Ghanaian economy or not? He could not have been in charge and also not be in charge at the same time. They have to decide and stay consistent.

Mr Speaker, the records show that the GoldBod arrangement, which is responsible for the successes that we have chalked with the Ghana cedi, was contained in our 2020 manifesto. It was proposed as a solution to perennial shortages in forex accumulation and depreciation of our currency. We also know that the whole gold for reserve policy was a “Hail Mary” attempt. Mr Speaker, I am sure you follow American football. So, you do know that in the course of American football, when one team is losing and the clock is winding down, they take a long shot in the hope that they will score. After they depleted our reserves, they were desperate and therefore had to resort to this gold for reserve policy, which was riddled with a lack of transparency. So, they have to tone down the efforts to usurp the work done by the GoldBod. They must give credit where it is due.

In any event, how is it that they were able to implement this gold for reserve

policy and yet our currency depreciated to the extent that it did? How is it that the policy that they say was ingenious did not yield any results and that at the same time that they were implementing the policy, our currency was stumbling? Yet our currency has responded to the policy initiative of this administration. As we speak, Ghanaians are feeling the relief. Everywhere we go, Mr Speaker, the prices of thousands of commodities and items on the markets have come down. And it is a direct consequence—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

Hon Members, let me bring it to your notice that I am not the one controlling the time; the IT department controls the time. When you have a minute left, the light will start blinking. When the light blinks, it does not mean your time is up. Once the time is up, you will be automatically cut off. So, I am not the one controlling the time.

It is now the turn of Dr Kabiru Tiah Mahama.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, just before the last speaker from our Side, the Minister of State for Government Communications used the term “Hail Mary”. The Catholics are offended. The Second Deputy Speaker is a Catholic, and he is not happy with that. It should be expunged. He said it was a “Hail Mary” attempt. It is an insult to the Catholics.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, I think you are out of

order. It is now the turn of Dr Kabiru Tiah Mahama.

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance has started what will, arguably, be the death of a policy I thought would survive beyond today. He has committed three sins, and those sins are actually speaking to the bad omen around this policy. First, the sin of selective amnesia. That sin is so fatal that if we choose to give a history of Eurobond issuers for a particular period of eight years, losing sight of the years before, it is the first sin that is going to bring doom to this policy.

Mr Speaker, the second sin is the sin of propaganda. That is when one wants to highlight a policy to rally around the House and get everyone on board; one must acknowledge leaders of old who have initiated similar things on which he is building.

4:35 p.m.

It cannot be true, and it is never true, and it ought not to stand in this House, that this is the first time we are contemplating as a country on a policy for the accumulation of reserves that is anchored on natural resources or commodities. It cannot be true, and the House should reflect that the Bank of Ghana has initiated this policy. The current leadership of the Bank of Ghana has actually acknowledged the previous attempts by previous leaders to accumulate reserves. So that is the first thing.

Mr Speaker, the second thing I want to correct before I even go to the substantive and that is the third mistake.

Mr Speaker, the third mistake is that when they rise to contribute to the Motion, they are failing to be religious to the facts. When Hon Adongo rose to say that the gold reserve was GH¢8 billion, it was a total falsehood. We left reserves of GH¢9.1 billion, and it is in the Bank of Ghana report.

Mr Speaker, the second misinformation is that they were doing 0.8 months of import cover. The Bank of Ghana report stated that we left office with four months of import cover, which he served as a Board member. Mr Speaker, that is another misinformation.

Mr Speaker, he said that the Bank of Ghana is not propping up the cedi with annual or monthly introduction of US\$1 billion to prop up our cedi; that is also another falsehood because the Bank of Ghana itself admitted and termed it what we call “market intimidation.” So, these are the facts before this House, and when they rise to speak to the facts, they should stay true and loyal to the facts.

Mr Speaker, let me now come to the broad contours of his policy, the GANRAP. It is anchored on nothing but commodities, namely; gold, crude oil, and cocoa prices. Gold is the only one sustaining it because we have had a record increase in prices from US\$2,600 per ounce to almost US\$5,000 now, as we have it. But crude oil prices are all on a nose dive.

Mr Speaker, so, when they are introducing a policy that is anchored on commodity pricing, they must have safeguards and risk mitigating measures. In this policy, Mr Speaker, there is absolutely nothing that speaks to the mitigating measures except to say that they are now going to have what they call, an energy sector payment plan or cocoa sector recovery plan. Cocoa has been mentioned only in one line; meanwhile, cocoa, before gold, was the mainstay of our country, and the major export of our country that supported our economy in those days. That is another problem.

Mr Speaker, I will then come to what they want to do. In terms of the measures, they mentioned that 20 per cent of large-scale gold would be harnessed, and that will translate to something like 0.57 ounces per week. Mr Speaker, I sat in a meeting at the Jubilee House where large gold miners were called through the Chamber of Mines, and we clearly stated to them, and they agreed to allow the Bank of Ghana to buy 20 per cent of their gold produce. So, what is new? Nothing is new in that particular measure, and then they would come and present it as if it were a new policy.

Mr Speaker, they are also talking of non-traditional export. We remember that President Kufuor took initiatives on the promotion of non-traditional exports.

Mr Speaker, they also talked about the cocoa sector reform and the development of new fields. Even the new field that they want to develop, it was

President Kufuor who discovered the oil. So, when they come to this particular House and want to present a policy to the Government or to the people of Ghana, they must contemplate that they need policy coherence. That they need the people of Ghana to support them in this policy and not come with half-truths to present it as if it is the Holy Grail, and that, for the first time, we are having an accelerated gold reserve programme. It is not true. Mr Speaker, in the fullness of time, during the debate of the Motion, we will expose the lie—

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, it is now the turn of Hon Kwame Agbodza.

Hon Kwame Agbodza, your time now starts.

Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza (NDC — Adaklu): Mr Speaker, I want to congratulate the Minister for Finance for this ambitious policy outdooing on the floor of this House. Indeed, Ghana can do better if we can build up a reserve for 15 months.

Mr Speaker, I think the presentation also answers one of the requirements of the respected Minority Leader when he said that the Statement must be factual, and the Statement has been very factual, unlike a Statement that was quoted using Psalm 23 to 118, which was full of non-factuals.

Mr Speaker, did I hear my Colleague criticising this policy? His problem is that he is pretending to have a reason to

criticise everything. Where is Dr Kabiru Mahama? He has even left the room just after his comment.

Mr Speaker, when they were doing the Gold for Oil policy, they did not even bring any paper to this House to present to Members of Parliament. This is the difference between them and the National Democratic Congress (NDC).

Mr Speaker, let me tell them this. I heard Dr Kabiru Mahama talking about the fact that we did not say anything about cocoa. I wish he were here when he actually said that he sat in a meeting when they had a discussion about the gold people. He also probably sat in a meeting that decided to pay US\$29 million to a contractor to build a road between Savelugu and Walewale. *[Interruption]* Hold on, because he linked it to cocoa.

Mr Speaker, let me tell them, the US\$29 million that was paid to the Indian contractor who did no work could have bought 123,000 bags of cocoa, and guess what, the US\$100 million spent on the Cathedral could have bought over 450,000 bags of cocoa. That is what they should have done. But let us look at it. Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader should listen to this if his Government matched this achievement.

Mr Speaker, we are saying that when they left inflation at 23.8 per cent, today, inflation is at 3.8 per cent. Are they not excited? Today, a 90 Day Treasury Bill, which they left at 27.7 per cent, today, it is 11 per cent. Today, businesses can borrow money and do proper business.

Even including cocoa farmers can borrow cheaper under this Government, and the public debt that they left at 61 per cent, today is 45 per cent. So, what exactly are they doing?

Mr Speaker, let me tell them this. I heard that, in fact, the Minister for Finance just told me that so all along, when they said we had reserves of about four months, they were pretending that we had money. So, they go to borrow money from the World Bank and very expensive loans, come and put it in their account, and then pay interest on it. Who does that? When one is broke and borrows money, one applies it to something that can generate revenue. But not knowing, all they were doing with Mr Ken Ofori-Atta was to borrow money expensively and put it in their bank account as if it were theirs and charge interest on it. That is a very lazy way of managing an economy. So, what we are saying is that these policies will anchor the future of our children. To build reserves so that we do not wake up one day and say that once the price of a commodity falls, within two weeks, the cedi is falling? Today, I can hear them say, "Look at what will happen, and the cedi will fall", but by the grace of God, the cedi will continue to disgrace them. The cedi is stable. Their wishes will never come to pass. President Mahama is obviously a better president than President Akufo-Addo, and whoever will take over from President Mahama will surely be a better president than whoever they are talking about.

Mr Speaker, let me repeat, I said that the US\$100 million they spent on

the Cathedral could have bought 450,000 bags of cocoa. The US\$29 million spent on the Walewale Road, for which he wants no road, could have bought another 120,000 bags of cocoa. So, if anybody has cheated cocoa farmers, they have cheated cocoa farmers.

Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

4:45 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is now the turn of the Minority Leader.

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Thank you for the opportunity to make a comment on the Statement by the Hon Minister for Finance. The Minister for Finance came to this House with his technical team, sought the leave of the House to present to us a document he has conveniently titled, “Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy 2026 to 2028”. Having completed that duty, the 188 of his own Side seemed not to be excited. Mr Speaker, we are not managing an economy to talk about numbers that have no direct correlation and benefit to the ordinary people on the streets of Accra.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance is here talking about inflation. What is inflation? When we go to the market and we cannot afford and we say inflation. The Minister for Finance, came here talking to us about some 15 months

import cover. Mr Speaker, we are not interested in his economic theories. *[Interruption]* Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance must know that this House is not interested in his new theories.

The people of Ghana, and I start from the youth were promised one job, three shifts. I expect him as a Minister for Finance to come to this House to address us on effort he is making. It has been one year. The Minister for Finance’s own constituent, he should give us data on how many people has he employed? In Jomoro, in Evalue Gwira, and in Effutu. The Minister for Road and Highways in his own constituency Adaklu, how many people have benefited from job creation policy? They come to this House, and tell us 15 months import cover and they come and spend a whole one hour when their people have no jobs.

Mr Speaker, even when it comes to the recruitment, it is a complete scam and I will explain to them. The recruitment into Ghana Police Service, Ghana Immigration Service, and Ghana Prisons Service. They are now even telling the youth that they should go and buy forms. They should go behind computer and do aptitude tests. In this country, how many areas have internet? The youth are spending more. The youth who are already unemployed, they are borrowing to spend, to have access to computer. These are things that they have ignored. They come and sit here and say “macro, macro”— *[Expunged by Orders of Mr Speaker]*. Macro and accumulation. Minister for Finance, I am not interested

in your macro numbers. I am interested in the bread-and-butter issues. Electricity, on paper they have increased electricity tariffs by over 30 per cent.

Put the numbers on paper aside. For those of them who, because they are in Government, they are ignoring the relatives on the ground. Ghanaians cannot afford electricity. They should know this. These are the things they should introduce policies for reform on how to reform the energy sector. They are not doing that. They come here and say “macro”. I will not commend them for doing this. I am not going to praise them.

Electricity needs reforms. Those are the *bona fides* they must pay attention to. Then they say 15 months, and Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation. When we buy electricity—

Mr Speaker, this morning, somebody told me that she used to buy 1,000 for a whole month. Today, even if you buy 2,000 for one-week— Mr Speaker, let us be careful what we tell the people of Ghana. We are talking about electricity. The National Democratic Congress (NDC) came into office. When they came into office, the first thing they did was to increase electricity tariffs. Instead of pursuing reforms under their own Reset agenda, they increased electricity, totalling 30 per cent. I repeat, the reality is that electricity tariffs have gone up by over 100 per cent because, the consumption—the people on the street in our constituencies, what they buy is unable to sustain them. They know the

numbers. They know how much they purchased in 2024. They know what they were buying in 2023 as compared to what they are buying now. Mr Speaker, that is the reality.

Next is the cocoa. Our cocoa farmers have been a supporting pillar of our economy since the days of Gold Coast. This Government came into being and they have abandoned all the supporting pillars of the economy. I do not need to be an economist to understand what leads to economic growth. My basic ideas as an entrepreneur are enough for me to know that when we create opportunities, the economy grows.

Mr Speaker, this Government promised that upon assumption of office, a bag of cocoa will be increased to GH¢6,000. The Minister for Finance said so, the Ranking Member on the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs said so. Mr Speaker, today, they have rather reduced the producer price. At the comfort of his office, the Minister for Finance reduced the producer price. Cocoa farmers—*[Expunged by Orders of Mr Speaker]*. You sat in your office and reduced producer price of cocoa. Thousand Ghana cedis is what you took away. Cocoa farmers cannot pay fees. They are borrowed from the cocoa *krakye*. They cannot take care of their health. Those matters do not concern them. Then they come and say Ghana Accelerated National Reserve. What we demand from you, Mr Finance Minister, is to immediately restore the producer price of cocoa that they came to meet. If you

cannot increase, do not reduce it. If you cannot increase, do not reduce it. That is the reality. That is the reality, Hon Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, again, instead of the Minister for Finance introducing incentives to grow the economy, he is not. What businesses need is rebates, tax breaks. What businesses need is a proper environment to grow their business. The Minister is not offering any of that. There are no incentives in the economy. No employment, and then they come here to tell us that, indeed, we should allow them to create a certain reserve accumulation. What is reserve accumulation when your own constituents are hungry? Their people are tired of their promises. They do politics of sloganeering. Enough of the slogans. Create jobs! Create jobs! One job, three shifts, they were the ones who said it. Create jobs.

4:55 p.m.

They said it. Create the jobs! One job, three shifts—they said it. Create the jobs. Go to Dansoman, Ablekuma North and Ablekuma South, they fought. [*Uproar*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, the arrangements—please, can you for once listen? You do not want to listen to me?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: There was no such arrangement. Leaders were not restricted and the Majority Leader knows.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, Minority Leader, I do not want to engage in any banter with you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: I am not. If you had told me 10 minutes I would have prepared accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: If you can hear me out.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: I must not be cut this way.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The time allocation and arrangements were made before I took over. I indicated right from the beginning that I am not the one controlling the time. Once your time is up, you will be cut automatically. So, please, it is now—Hon Members, order! Can we have some order? Let me make it clear that I indicated right from the beginning that I do not have control over the time. I did indicate it. So, once your time is up, it will be cut automatically. So, Hon Members, it is now the turn. [*Uproar*]

Hon Members, what is the sense of the House? I think we are speaking for five minutes and Leaders are given ten minutes; double of the time. It is fixed automatically. Once the time is up—Let me hear the Majority Leader. Yes, Majority Leader, what is the sense of the House?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think there is some genuine misunderstanding. You are right, but also the Minority Leader is right. The reason I say so is that as the debate proceeded, we had actually

not taken a decision on the time to be allotted to Leaders. But while the debate was going on, my Second Deputy Whip consulted me and asked “how many minutes per leader”? And I said, “I do not know”. He said, “how about ten minutes since each Member is speaking for five minutes”? And I said, “well, ten minutes should be fine because the main debate is tomorrow”. The idea today was just to comment on whatever the Hon Minister was going to say. But the actual debate is tomorrow.

I believe that the communication then went to you that Leaders will speak for ten minutes. I do not know if we conveyed the message to our Hon Colleagues on the other Side. So, I think there is a genuine communication gap. To deal with this, I think we can even up by agreeing on 15 minutes.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but we must place on record that no communication came to me. If it came to the Rt Hon Speaker before he handed over to me, I would not be able to say. That is why I maintain that for today, I am not the timekeeper. They are keeping the time somewhere. So, once your time is up, I have no control. What is the sense of the House? I am not even the one cutting the time. So, the timekeepers—[**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, you must hear our Side too for *Hansard*] You see, Minority Leader, sometimes the way you do things —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, do not take issue with me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am not taking issue with you. I just do not want to go there. I am just controlling myself.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, then you should talk to your Side. I also deserve respect. Look at their behaviour. Their Backbenchers do not come into our matter. When their Leader stood up, the Minority Side kept quiet. They should not worry; I am able to take this up. Whenever any of their Side is up, our Side, accords them that respect.
[*Interruption*]

Mr Agbodza: When I got up, they heckled me.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: You are not a Leader. Hon Agbodza is not the Leader; he should sit down. He is not in Leadership. He should sit down. He should let the Backbench copy rightly from him.

Mr Speaker, our concern is very simple. I have heard Hon Ampem and I will respond to him at the right time. He should continue that disrespect.

Mr Speaker, we understood it to mean that the other speakers were going to have five minutes each. Like the Majority Leader explained, nothing was communicated to us. To be frank with you, if I was told that I had five minutes or even two minutes, I have my notes, I would have chosen which point to pursue. Mr Speaker, this argument that somebody is keeping their time and the person has clocked in ten minutes, was not communicated.

And to Hon Richard Acheampong, we operate in this Chamber on the basis of good faith. If indeed what the Leader said was a true position, he could have gently moved across, communicated to Alhaji Habib Iddrisu that this is the proposal, and we would comply. But when he does this, he creates a bad situation for this House and those of us here, and it is unfair. I saw him winking. There are things we can joke with, and there are matters we cannot joke with, because it makes me look bad and it makes the Speaker also look bad. So, he should stop it. In future, he should communicate well and let us do the right thing. Mr Speaker, we need to pursue the debate. I need to go on and then when I finish, the Majority Leader can also come.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, if you cannot reach a consensus, then I would want to go by the Rules. Now, this Statement is made under Order 91 of our Standing Orders. Order 91(4) says, “A Member commenting on the Statement shall not take more than five minutes except otherwise permitted by the Speaker.”. For now, I am presiding as the Speaker. I determine whether you can go beyond ten minutes.

5:05 p.m.

Since the House cannot come to a consensus as to the number of minutes that the Leaders should speak, I will therefore rule that, going by the Standing Orders, no Leader is going beyond 10 minutes. Now, I will proceed on Order 63 to expunge from the record everything said by the Minority Leader

in Twi that was not been translated into the English language.

Majority Leader, you have the floor. You are not going beyond 10 minutes.
[Uproar]

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, I honestly think that a very important national Policy has been presented to us as a Parliament and this is the first time it has happened. Mr Speaker, I can hear Friends opposite indicating that this is not the first time there is an attempt to create a reserve, and that the Gold for Oil (G4O) Policy was meant to create a reserve. But at least at that time, we did not have the benefit of a coherent policy document presented to Parliament for us to consider, debate, and approve. It would have been part of the records of this House.

Today, there is a Policy document presented to this House, and we are seeking to detract from the importance and the value of the presentation that has been made. I think this is most unfortunate. So, Mr Speaker, it is not every day that my Brother, the Minority Leader, will prevail. He must learn to accept even when he is not prevailing. He has made his point, and everybody has seen that. I even got up and supported his position. But unfortunately, we as Leaders were not told the time. That I admit it. I do not see the need to continue to engage in banter with the Speaker. I am going to suffer that, because I am going to speak for only 10 minutes, and I have already spent about four minutes of that time trying to address this situation.

So please, Minority Leader, let us focus on the Business of the day. Mr Speaker, tomorrow, there is going to be a full-blown debate on this matter. So tomorrow, he will have the opportunity to say everything that he wants to say before we approve the Policy document. So, there is no need for us to spend all the time engaging in a fight. *[Interruption]* Mr Speaker, strictly speaking — *[Interruption]*. Please, he should stop doing what he is doing. When he was speaking, I kept quiet and listened to him. When I am speaking, he should not interject the way he is doing. Strictly speaking, the Speaker is right. The rules say five minutes for every Member. When we go to Questions, it makes an exception for Leaders to ask more than one after the main Question has been asked. So, where the rules intend to make an exception, they make a clear exception. The rules do not say that if one is a Leader, he can speak *ad infinitum*. No. The rules say five minutes for every Member commenting on a Statement, and that was a Statement, and the time is five minutes.

It is only a privilege that the Speaker has conferred on us by allowing us as Leaders to speak for 10 minutes. So, he cannot take the Speaker on for allowing him 10 minutes when the rules even say five minutes. He can only plead. If he pleads and the Speaker accepts, that is it. If the Speaker does not accept, that is it. This is not necessary. Tomorrow, we will have a full-blown debate on the Report. Please, the First Deputy Speaker is also our Colleague.

Mr Speaker, in keeping with the rules, I will not say much. All I can say in response to what has been said is that this Policy is simply to deal with the problem of a rainy day. Today is a sunny day, where gold prices have shot up, and they are US\$5,000 per ounce from US\$2,000 thereabouts. We are benefiting from this; we do not know what the future holds. And a visionary leadership and a visionary Minister for Finance, has to think about tomorrow if commodity prices are not as good as they are today. Just last week, we witnessed a slump in the price of cocoa. When cocoa prices were high, if we had such visionary leaders, and we had saved in preparation for when prices came down, we would not have been demonstrating in the streets. We would have had a buffer to support us to be able to cushion the cocoa farmers. So, if you are interested in the welfare of cocoa farmers, you must be interested in this Policy that is being introduced today because it is also to cushion both the cocoa farmer and the gold miner in the future when the prices slump.

So, this is the essence of today. We learn from the mistakes of the past. We did not take advantage of the past when prices were very high. Today, we want to put in place a policy and a mechanism that will enable us to harness the opportunity provided by the huge gold prices to create a reserve that in the future we can depend on as an economy. Mr Speaker, I hear arguments that what is the benefit of a good reserve? Let me just take cement prices. Because of the good policies that have been implemented, the cedi appreciated in

relation to the dollar. As a result, when we imported 60,000 metric tonnes of clinker, we paid a duty of GH¢16 million under the New Patriotic Party (NPP) Government. Now, as a result of the reduction in the dollar exchange rate, when we import the same 60,000 metric tonnes of clinker, we pay a duty of only GH¢11.5 million; from GH¢16 million to GH¢11.5 million.

Mr Speaker, this is the benefit of implementing policies like that. This low price is being transferred to the consumer, the person buying the cement. That is why cement prices have come down from GH¢115 per bag to GH¢85 per bag. That is why the price of Polyvinyl Chloride (PVC) pipes has come down from GH¢15.00 per 20mm PVC pipe to GH¢9.00. That is how the price of petrol has come down from GH¢80.00 to GH¢49.00. *[Hear! Hear!]* Mr Speaker, I can go on and on and on, because the policies are translating into the lives of our people.

5:15 p.m.

They are paying lower prices. Indeed, I know there are complaints that the prices are not going down as much as the consumers expect because when they see government interventions, they expect impact that will be higher but we know that with time we will get there. But no one can deny the fact that these policies are translating into improvements in the living conditions of our people. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, let me make the last point. He talked about job creation. The

Ghana Statistical Service reported that in the last 12 months, one million people have found jobs in the Ghana economy. *[Uproar]* One million people have found jobs. Go to the Ghana Statistical Service. They reported that in the last quarter of 2024, the number of people who are working—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, you have exhausted your time.

Hon Members, the Hon Minister for Finance at the conclusion of the Statement requested that Parliament consider and approve the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy, 2026 to 2028. The Rt Hon Speaker has given some inclination. Based on that inclination, I will refer the Statement to the Finance Committee for consideration and reports to the House tomorrow as a matter of urgency. Hon Members, thank you. *[Pause]*

Well, the sense is that the Committee on Economy and Development—so I direct that the Committee on Economy and Development joins the Finance Committee to consider the Statement and report to the House.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, kindly consider directing that they should submit their report tomorrow for adoption by this House. We have variously announced that there will be an opportunity to debate tomorrow. So let us have the Report submitted tomorrow for adoption by this House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Habib Iddrisu?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, they want us to rush a serious government policy like this within 24 hours, why? It has just been given to us. Hon Members need to read it; the Committee need to meet and consider it. So Mr Speaker, to say you should direct that they should report back to the House by tomorrow, the time is inadequate for the Committee to consider it. I do not know whether it is the case that they just want to clear and add it to the Message on the State of the Nation.

Mr Speaker, we are preparing towards the Message on the State of the Nation, so and we are closing early tomorrow. We are moving the Motion on the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy tomorrow, as the Rt Hon Speaker has said. So, to say they should report tomorrow, the time is inadequate, Mr Speaker. We cannot get the Report by tomorrow.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I believe the issue that we cannot get the Report tomorrow is not tenable because if the Finance Committee would not be able to work within that time frame, I expect the Members of the Finance Committee to communicate so. So, Finance Committee, as much as possible, if you can present your Report tomorrow, the House will take your Report.

Yes, Majority Leader, any indication?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, with your kind permission, the Road Traffic

Regulations, 2026 is ready for laying and the Minister is here. So, if you can indulge us to vary the order of Business to the item numbered 8 to lay the Road Traffic Regulations, 2026, then we can go back to Questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the application is to vary the order of Business to take the item numbered 8. All right, Hon Members, silence means consent. We vary the order of Business to take the item numbered 8, at the Commencement of Public Business, Presentation of Instruments.

Yes, Hon Minister for Transport.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, I want to draw the attention of Majority Leader to the fact that this is not a one-Sided House. Mr Speaker, as much as possible, he has to engage. On the issue of the referral to the Finance Committee and the Committee on Economy and Development, he just came out with the suggestion that they should report tomorrow.

Mr Speaker, at least it is fair that given the fact that the documents are even yet to be distributed to Members. And this is supposed to be such an important policy document. Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader cannot just say that there should be a Report of this tomorrow, when he knows that the Rt Hon Speaker scheduled tomorrow for

this House to take the Motion on the losses of Gold Board, which IMF has reported to be GHC7 billion. This House is to debate this matter tomorrow, and then the Majority Leader says that there should be another Motion tomorrow?

Mr Speaker, this is a two-Sided House. Democracy has an ear for the Minority. I would plead with the Hon Majority Leader, to let us build consensus on these matters. Tomorrow is too short a time. We can look at the Report next week.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, at the commencement of public Business, Presentation of Papers. Yes, Hon Minister for Transport?

INSTRUMENT

Road Traffic Regulations, 2026

Laid by the Minister for Transport (Mr Joseph Nikpe Bukari).

Referred to the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we can now go on the item numbered 6, Questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will call on the Minister for Roads and Highways to take the designated seat, and respond to the Questions scheduled for him? I will proceed to the question numbered 584, standing in the name of

Hon Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi, Member of Parliament for Asante Akim Central.

5:25 p.m.

Mr Collins Adomako-Mensah: Mr Speaker, with your permission, I have the authority of the Member to ask the Question on his behalf.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, please do.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF ROADS AND HIGHWAYS

Completion of the Konongo Zongo– Praaso through Dwease Road Project

Mr Collins Adomako-Mensah *on behalf of Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi (NPP — Asante Akim Central):* Mr Speaker, I rise to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the Konongo Zongo to Praaso through Dwease Road will be completed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza) (MP): Mr Speaker, Ministers are encouraged to be here to answer Questions, and I have been coming here. Mr Speaker, can we also say that Members who fail to come and ask the Questions, the Answers should be published. [*Uproar*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I always admonish that we are

all Members of Parliament. Sometimes, certain things flow when the Minister is not available to answer a Question. Though the Minister will write to the House explaining the circumstances, but when we get the microphone, things that we place on record – Hon Members, sometimes danger begets a man, the cry of distress may summon for relief. So, we are getting onto the record what we get sometimes, flowing from what we do to ourselves as Members of Parliament. So, Hon Minister, I will call upon you to do nothing but to respond to the Questions.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, I will comply accordingly. This is my response to the Question numbered 584.

Konongo Zongo to Praaso through Dwease Road

Background

The Konongo Zongo to Praaso through Dwease is a 25.6 km inter-district road that connects Asante Akim Central Municipality to Asante Akim South Municipality of the Ashanti Region. It is an engineered, bitumen-surfaced road in poor condition.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the road.

Future Programme

Engineering design studies and cost estimates have been carried out on the road for consideration upon the availability of funds.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, do you have a supplementary question?

Mr Adomoako-Mensah: No, please.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Hon Member, this is a constituency-specific Question. We will move to the Question numbered 551 standing in the name of Dr Grace Ayensu-Danquah, Member of Parliament for Essikadu Ketan. You have the floor.

Status of Kansawrodo–Mampong– Abaasa and Mpinstin–Eshien– Ntamakrom–Angu Road Projects

Dr Grace Ayensu-Danquah (NDC — Essikadu Ketan): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the status of the following roads: (i) Kansawrodo – Mampong – Abaasa (ii) Mpinstin – Eshien – Ntamakrom – Angu.

Mr Agbodza: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Kansawrodo — Mampong

Background

Essikadu Ketan sub-metro lies in the eastern part of the Sekondi-Takoradi Metropolitan Assembly. The Kansawrodo – Mampong Road connects the E. Akuffo Addo Road, which is a bypass off the N1. The road provides access to the aforementioned communities.

Current Programme

The Kansawrodo-Mampong Road as well as the KNUST Institute of Distance Learning (IDL) road have been earmarked for rehabilitation under the contract “Upgrading of Selected Roads in Essikadu-Ketan Sub-Metropolitan Area Lot 1 (6.52 km)”. The contract commenced on 23rd April, 2019 for completion by 22nd October, 2020.

To date, 3.4 km of the Kansawrodo-Mampong Road has been constructed from gravel to Asphalt Binder Course. The physical progress of works is 61 per cent.

The contractor has abandoned site due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

Future Programme

Engineering studies and cost estimates will be carried out on the Mampong-Abaasa section of the road for consideration based on the availability of funds.

Mpinstin – Eshien – Ntamakrom – Angu

This road is within the Sekondi-Takoradi Metropolis in the Western Region. It is a 15 km engineered road in poor condition. There is currently no programme of this road. Engineering and design studies and cost estimate would be carried out on the road upon availability of funds.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Dr Ayensu-Danquah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I need to know when the contractor abandoned the site.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the contract period, as I said, was from 2019 to 2020. Obviously, the contractor left site sometime after 2020 without completing the work.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further question?

Dr Ayensu-Danquah: No further questions. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is also constituency specific. We move to the Question numbered 552, standing in the name of Hon Felix Akwetey Okle, Bortiano-Ngleshie Amanfro Constituency.

Mr Felix Akwetey Okle (NDC — Bortianor Ngleshie-Amanfro): Thank you Mr Speaker. With your permission, I would like to come under Order 90(2) to withdraw my Question and to thank the Hon Minister for the great construction work that is happening in my constituency currently as I speak. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Leave is hereby granted. Question accordingly withdrawn. We move to the Question

numbered 580 standing in the name of Bright Asamoah Brefo, Member of Parliament for Bibiani/Anhwiaso/Bekwai.

Completion of Ongoing Road Projects in Bibiani and Sefwi-Bekwai

Mr Bright Asamoah Brefo (NDC — Bibiani/Anhwiaso/Bekwai): Mr Speaker, I rise to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the steps the Ministry is taking to ensure the timely completion of the ongoing projects in Bibiani and Sefwi-Bekwai.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, there are about eight different projects under this Question so I will start with the first one.

The under-listed eight (8) feeder roads projects are currently ongoing in the Bibiani-Anhwiaso-Bekwai Municipality of the Western North Region:

- (i) Bitumen surfacing of Subri Nkwanta – Chirano – Akoti Feeder Roads (24.30 km)
- (ii) Upgrading of Subri Town roads (0.8 km), Bekwai – Sukusuku (1.00 km), Atwima – Sonkori – Bankromisa (2.70 km), and Akaasu Jn – Akaasu (0.60 km) Feeder Roads, totalling (5.10 km)
- (iii) Upgrading of Asawinso – Mmrewa – Nkronua Feeder Roads (21.00 km).
- (iv) Upgrading of Sefwi Atronsu – Compound (1.50 km), Adobewora No. 2 - Alata (1.00 km) and

Chiraa Jn.- Chiraa (1.50 km) Feeder Roads, totalling (4.0 km).

- (v) Upgrading of Dominibo No. 2 – Abodiabo – Chine Feeder Road (11.40 km)
- (vi) Upgrading of Pataboase – Chirano Feeder Road (12.0 km)
- (vii) Upgrading of Tanoso – Adupri Feeder Road (5.8 km)
- (viii) Spot improvement of Basingele - Mframakrom & other Feeder Roads (5.70 km)
- (i) Subri Nkwanta – Chirano – Akoti Feeder Road (24.30 km)

Background

The Subri Nkwanta – Chirano – Akoti road (24.3 km) is a connector road located in the Bibiani-Anhwiaso-Bekwai Municipality of the Western North Region. It is an engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Subri Nkwanta – Chirano – Akoti Feeder Road was awarded under the contract titled “Bitumen surfacing of Subri Nkwanta – Chirano - Akoti feeder Road (24.30 km)”.

The Subri Nkwanta – Chirano - Akoti Feeder Road (24.30 km) was initially awarded, and additional 7.95 km of roads was approved through a Variation Order.

The contract was awarded on 5th April, 2018 for completion by 16th September, 2020 with a revised completion date of 16th December, 2024. The progress of work is 100 per cent physical completion.

- (ii) Subri Town roads (0.8 km), Bekwai – Sukusuku (1.00 km), Atwima – Sonkori – Bankromisa (2.70 km), and Akaasu Jn – Akaasu (0.60 km) Feeder Roads, totalling (5.10 km)

Background

The Subri Town Roads (0.8 km), Bekwai – Sukusuku (1.00 km), Atwima – Sonkori – Bankromisa (2.70 km), and Akaasu Jn – Akaasu (0.60 km) Feeder Roads, totaling 5.10 km are in the Bibiani-Anhwiaso-Bekwai Municipality of the Western North Region. They are engineered gravel roads in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Subri Town Roads (0.8km), Bekwai – Sukusuku (1.00km), Atwima – Sonkori – Bankromisa (2.70km), and Akaasu Jn – Akaasu (0.60km) Feeder Roads, totaling 5.10km were awarded as one package for upgrading to bitumen surfacing. The contract was awarded on 31st May, 2024 for completion by 15th October, 2025.

The overall progress of work is estimated at 35 per cent physical completion.

5:35 p.m.

The contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

- (iii) Asawinso – Mmrewa – Nkronua Feeder Road (21.00 km)

Background

The Asawinso – Mmrewa – Nkronua Feeder Road (21.00 km) is a connector road located in Bibiani-Anhwiaso-Bekwai Municipality of the Western North Region. It is an engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Asawinso – Mmrewa – Nkronua Feeder Road was awarded under the contract titled “Upgrading of Asawinso – Mmrewa – Nkronua Feeder Road (21.00 km)”. The contract was awarded on 30th October, 2024 for completion by 10th August, 2026. The overall progress of works is estimated at 15.2 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

- (iv) Sefwi Atronsu – Compound (1.50 km), Adobewora No. 2 - Alata (1.00 km) and Chiraa Jn.- Chiraa (1.50 km) Feeder Roads, totalling (4.0 km).

Background

The Sefwi Atronsu – Compound (1.50 km), Adobewora No. 2 - Alata (1.00 km) and Chiraa Jn. - Chiraa (1.50 km) Feeder Roads, totaling 4km are in the Bibiani-Anhwiaso-Bekwai Municipality of the Western North Region. They are engineered gravel roads in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Sefwi Atronsu – Compound (1.50 km), Adobewora No. 2 - Alata (1.00 km) and Chiraa Jn. - Chiraa (1.50 km) Feeder Roads were awarded under the contract titled “Upgrading of Sefwi Atronsu – Compound (1.50 km), Adobewora No. 2 - Alata (1.00 km) and Chiraa Jn. - Chiraa (1.50 km) Feeder Roads (4.00 km)”.

The contract was awarded on 4th October, 2024 for completion by 10th February, 2026. The overall progress of work is estimated at 10 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

- (v) Dominibo No. 2 – Abodiabo – Chine Feeder Road (11.40km)

Background

The Dominibo No.2 – Abodiabo – Chine Feeder Road (11.40km) is a connector road located in the Bibiani-Anhwiaso-Bekwai Municipality of the Western North Region. It is an

engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Dominibo No. 2 - Abodiabo – Chine Feeder Road (11.4km) was awarded under the contract titled “Upgrading of Dominibo No.2 - Abodiabo – Chine Feeder Road (11.4km)”.

The contract was awarded on 28th February, 2020 for completion by 9th October, 2021. The overall progress of work is estimated at 35 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

- (vi) Pataboase – Chirano Feeder Road (12.0km)

Background

The Pataboase – Chirano Feeder Road (12 km) is a connector road located in the Bibiani-Anhwiaso-Bekwai Municipality of the Western North Region. It is an engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Pataboase – Chirano Feeder Road (12km) was awarded under the contract titled “Upgrading of Pataboase – Chirano Feeder Road (12.0km)”.

The contract was awarded on 28th February, 2020 for completion by 9th

December, 2021. The overall progress of work is estimated at 62 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

(vii) Tanoso – Adupri Feeder Road (5.8km)

Background

The Tanoso - Adupri Feeder Road (5.8km) is a connector road located in the Bibiani-Anhwiaso-Bekwai Municipality of the Western North Region. It is an engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Tanoso - Adupri Feeder Road (5.8km) was awarded under the contract titled “Upgrading of Tanoso – Adupri Feeder Road (4.3km) and Afamu Jn – Afamu (1.5km) Feeder Road (5.8km)”.

The contract was awarded on 2nd February, 2023 for completion by 11th April, 2024. The overall progress of work is estimated at 78 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

(ix) Basingele - Mframakrom Feeder Road (5.7km)

Background

The Basingele - Mframakrom Feeder Road (5.7km) is a connector road located in the Bibiani-Anhwiaso-Bekwai Municipality of the Western North Region. It is an engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Basingele - Mframakrom Feeder Road (5.7km) was awarded under the contract titled “Spot Improvement of Basingele - Mframakrom Feeder Road (5.7km)”.

The contract was awarded on 19th August, 2020 for completion by 28th October, 2021 with a revised completion date of 28th August, 2023. The overall progress of work is estimated at 64.3 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

The Department of Urban Roads has three (3) ongoing projects in Bibiani with a total length of 13.48km. Completion of these projects will improve the road and drainage conditions of the municipality. The projects are at various levels of completion.

Current Programme

Rehabilitation of Selected Roads in Bibiani, Western North (1.98km).

The contract commenced on 6th February, 2025 for completion by 8th May, 2026. The overall progress of work is estimated at 12.12 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently on site and works are ongoing.

Completion of Bibiani Town Roads, Western North (6.5km)

The contract commenced on 6th February, 2025 for completion by 6th February, 2027. The overall progress of work is estimated at 5.58 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently on site and works are ongoing.

Rehabilitation of Bibiani Town Roads (5.0km)

The contract commenced on 28th April, 2020 for completion by 29th October, 2021. The overall progress of work is estimated at 46.72 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Brefo: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

GS International, the Chinese company which was undertaking the Bibiani Township Road, suspended its work because of—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are to ask a supplementary

question. Do you have any supplementary question?

Mr Brefo: It appears that most of the roads that the Minister talked about appears to have been given to one contractor and that has the potential to delay—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What is your supplementary question?

Mr Brefo: Thank you, Mr Speaker, I am done.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we move to the Question numbered 597, standing in the name of Alhaji Alhassan Mumuni, the Member of Parliament for Salaga North. You have the floor.

Completion of Some Roads in the Salaga North Municipality

Alhaji Alhassan Mumuni (NDC — Salaga North): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I rise to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the steps the Ministry is implementing to fix the following roads: Kpalbe – Vanne road, Kpalbe – Jinlo road and Tantuani – Kpalguni Road.

Mr Agbodza:

Background

Mr Speaker, the Kpalbe – Vanie (12.5km) and Kpalbe – Jinlo (11.7km) Roads are in the North East Gonja district of the Savannah Region. They are access roads linking the Kpalbe

township to the Vanie and Jinlo communities respectively. They are partially engineered roads in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the roads.

Future Programme

Engineering design studies and cost estimates have been carried out on the roads for consideration upon the availability of funds.

(iii) Tantuani – Kpalguni Road

Background

The Tantuani – Kpalguni Road is in the North East Gonja District of the Savannah Region. It is partially engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the road.

Future Programme

Engineering design studies and cost estimates will be carried out on the road for consideration upon the availability of funds.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Alhaji Alhassan Mumuni: No supplementary question. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: This is a constituency-specific; we move to the Question numbered 610, standing in the name of Dr Godfred Seidu Jasaw, Member of Parliament for Wa East.

Commencement of Rehabilitation Works on Roads in the Wa East Municipality

Godfred Seidu Jasaw (NDC — Wa East): I rise to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when rehabilitation works will commence on the following roads: Wa – Bulenga Kundugu and Wa – Loggu – Jeyiri – Tuosa

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the Wa–Bulenga–Kundungu section forms a critical component of the Inter- Regional Road Yawgu–Yaala (I-011), serving as a strategic corridor that links the Upper West Region to the North East Region.

Current Programme

The Wa – Bulenga – Kundugu Road was awarded in two (2) Lots under contracts titled as follows:

Upgrading of Wa-Bulenga-Yaala Road (km 6-37)

Upgrading of Wa-Bulenga-Yaala Road (km 37-74)

Upgrading of Wa-Bulenga-Yaala Road (km 6-37)

The contract commenced on 3rd March, 2020 with a revised completion date of 30th September, 2026. The project is at 68 per cent physical completion. Works have stalled due to delay in payment for works done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

Upgrading of Wa-Bulenga-Yaala Road (km 37-74)”

The contract was awarded on 8th January, 2026 for completion by 2nd August, 2028. The contractor is currently on site and works are progressing steadily.

Wa – Loggu – Jeyiri – Tuosa road

Background

The Wa – Loggu – Jeyiri – Tuosa feeder road (49.7 km) is a connector road located in the Wa East district of the Upper West region. It is an engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Wa-loggu-Jeyiri-Tuosa Feeder Road was awarded under the contract titled “Spot Improvement of Katua-Holomuni Feeder Road and others (121.60 km)”. The contract was awarded on 19th September, 2024 for completion by 11th May, 2026. The overall progress of work is estimated at 6.2 per cent physical completion.

The contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being

made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding work.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, do you have any supplementary questions?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, I wish to thank the Minister; he has done a lot of work so far on this request.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We would move to the Question numbered 613, standing in the name of Ms Shirley Kyei, Member of Parliament for Atwima Nwabiagya South.

Ms Fatahiya Abdul-Aziz: Mr Speaker, I have the authority of Ms Kyei to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the Question. I therefore seek your permission to do.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Once you have the authority, please ask the question.

5:45 p.m.

Resumption of construction works on some roads in Atwima Nwabiagya South

Ms Fatahiya Abdul Aziz on behalf of Ms Shirley Kyei (Atwima Nwabiagya South): Mr Speaker, we beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when construction works will resume on the following roads: (i) Wiosu – Amanchia (ii) Nkawie – Nkranfoase (iii) Ntabanum Junction – Ntabanum.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker,

(i) Wiosu – Amanchia road

Background

The Wiosu (Wioso) – Amanchia road forms part of the regional road R108 which starts from Wioso and joins R105 at Brofuyedru.

Current Programme

The Wioso – Amanchia road was awarded under the contract titled “Rehabilitation of Wioso - Moseaso (19.50 km) and Critical Accesses (5.0 km)”. The contract was awarded on 28th June 2024 for completion by 29th June, 2026. Physical progress of works stands at 35.8%. The Contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the Contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

(ii) Nkawie-Nkranfoase road

Background

The Nkawie-Nkran-Foase feeder road (17 km) is an Inter- District Road that connects Atwima Nwabiagya South District to Atwima Kwanwoma District of the Ashanti Region. It is an engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Nkwawie-Nkran-Foase feeder road was awarded under the contract titled “Upgrading of Nkawie Kuma-Nkran-Foase Feeder Road (17.00 km)”.

The contract commenced on 10th December, 2020 for completion by 5th November, 2023. The overall progress of work is estimated at 10 per cent physical completion. The Contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the Contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

(iii) Ntabanum Junction-Ntabanum Road

Background

The Ntabanum Junction-Ntabanum Road (12km) is an access from the Kumasi-Sunyani Highway located in the Atwima Nwabiagya South district of the Ashanti region. It is an engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Ntabanum Junction-Ntabanum feeder road was awarded under the contract titled “Upgrading of Ntabanum Junction-Ntabanum Feeder Road (12.00 km)”.

The contract was awarded on 23rd December, 2024. Works commenced on 10th February, 2025 for completion by 10th August, 2026. The overall progress of work is estimated at 15 per cent physical completion. The Contractor is currently on site and works are ongoing.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary?

Ms Fatahiya: Mr Speaker, I would like to ask the Hon Minister whether there are timelines to this process.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the first part, which is Wiosu – Amanchia the completion date is 29th of June, 2026. Nkawie-Nkranfoase, the completion date has passed, so the contractor is not on site and then Ntabanum Junction-Ntabanum Road, the completion date is August 2026, so the contractor is within the time period.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further supplementary questions?

Ms Fatahiya: Hon Minister, what are we doing to bring the contractor on site?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, many of the contractors are off site, as I said, even before 2024 election because we owe them over 40 billion. Last year alone, the Minister for Finance paid over 9.8 billion to retire a portion of the over 40 billion we owe contractors. Indeed, that means that we have a lot more to do. So, as much as possible, we would continue to work hard to find resources and pay contractors so that they can go back to site. It is indeed a very difficult situation for both residents of the public and the contractors off site and not working. So, we would continue to work to make sure we get resources to pay them so they can return to site and work. But as part of our annual maintenance programmes, we actually programme normal maintenance works on those roads to make sure there are motorable while we wait for the

contractor to come and complete outstanding works.

Ms Fatahiya: Mr Speaker, that will be all. Thank you for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We move to the question number 619, standing in the name of Dr Albert Tetteh Nyakotey, Member of Parliament for Yilo Krobo.

Mr Bismark Tetteh Nyarko: Mr Speaker, the Hon Member has authorised me to ask permission from you to ask the Question on his behalf.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do.

Resumption of works on the Somanya to Kpong Road

Mr Bismark Tetteh Nyarko on behalf of Dr Albert Tetteh Nyakotey (NDC — Yilo Krobo): Mr Speaker, we beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when work on the Somanya to Kpong road will resume after the contractor abandoned the project in January 2025.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, indeed, the contractor abandoned site, as I said, before 2024. But the contractor has since returned to site, and works have started.

Background

The Somanya-Kpong road forms part of R30 and intersects with the National Road N3, which connects Kpong through Oterkpolu to Koforidua. It is

also within the Yilo Krobo and Lower Manya Krobo Municipalities.

Current Programme

The road was awarded under the contract titled “Addendum No. 2 - Rehabilitation of Somanya (Traffic Light) – Kpong Road (11.3 km), Construction of Asitey-Somanya Road (4.3 km) and Construction of Odumase By-Pass Road (2.5 km) – Total Length = 18.1 km”. Works commenced on 9th December, 2024 for completion by 8th December, 2026. Physical progress is at 38 per cent. The Contractor resumed works at site in October, 2025 and is actively working on a Box Culvert, Retaining Wall and Storm Drain at km 6+000 on the Somanya - Kpong Road and drainage works on the Asitey Road.

Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Mr B. T. Nyarko: Mr Speaker, that will be all for now.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Question number 640, standing in the name of Hon Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo.

Reasons for the halt in upgrading of some roads in Manso Nkwanta

Mr Tweneboah Kodua Fokuo (Manso Nkwanta): I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways why the upgrading of Pakyi No. 2 – Antoakrom feeder road (21.30 km),

Trede – Pakyi No. 2 link (2.40km) and critical access (0.95km) have halted and the contractor has vacated the site.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the Pakyi No. 2 - Antoakrom feeder road (21.30 km), Trede-Pakyi No. 2 link (2.40 km) and critical access (0.95 km) roads

Background

The Pakyi No. 2 – Antoakrom (21.3 km) and Trede – Pakyi No. 2 (2.4 km) roads serve as connectors between Atwima Kwanwoma Municipal to Amansie West District of the Ashanti region. Both are engineered gravel roads in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Pakyi No. 2 - Antoakrom feeder road (21.30 km), Trede-Pakyi No. 2 link (2.40 km) and critical access (0.95 km) feeder roads were awarded under the contract titled “Upgrading of Pakyi No.2 - Antoakrom Feeder Road (21.30 km), Trede-Pakyi No. 2 Link (2.40 km) and Critical Access (0.95 km) Feeder Road (24.65 km)”. The contract commenced on 8th July, 2024 for completion by 7th July, 2026. The overall progress of work is estimated at 34 per cent physical completion. The Contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the Contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

Mr Fokuo: Mr Speaker, I would like to know from the Minister, when will the outstanding interim payment certificates for work already executed be paid to the contractor? Thank you.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, as I said, as of the time President Mahama took over, contractors were owed over GH¢40 billion for works done and not paid for. We have since retired GH¢9.8 billion of that, which is the highest ever payment to contractors within a period of time. It is the record payment. But as I said, if you owe even GH¢40 billion and you pay even GH¢15 billion, it presupposes that you still owe a lot of people, and you have to find the money and pay. We are working hard to continue to pay contractors so that they can return to site and complete outstanding works and we continue to do that on a daily basis.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further questions?

Mr Fokuo: Mr Speaker, I would like to know from the Minister if there are revised dates for completion of these roles. Because, from what I am getting, yes, they are not completed, there is no money, but do we have revised dates for completion of these roads?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the good news is that the contractor is still within the contractual period, because this project is supposed to be completed somewhere around 7th of July, 2026. So, we are not out of contract, so there is no need for a revision of the completion date yet.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any other questions?

Mr Fokuo: Mr Speaker, this is to get a bit of information to the Minister. Hon Minister, I would like to—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, the rules allow you to ask supplementary questions, but not to give information. You may see the Minister outside and give information to him.

Mr Fokuo: Mr Speaker, thank you. Hon Minister, are you aware there is no tarred road in the Manso Nkwanta Constituency?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, file a specific question.

Mr Fokuo: Mr. Speaker, I am sure the Minister can answer this question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Question overruled.

Mr Fokuo: Mr Speaker, I am guided. Thank you.

5:55 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We will move to the Question numbered 192, standing in the name of Hon Vincent Ekow Assafuah, Hon Member for Old Tafo —

Very well, thank you for the guidance. Hon Minister, thank you so much for attending upon the House to respond to all the Questions scheduled for you. You are accordingly discharged.

May I call on the Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment to take the designated seat and respond to Questions?

I will call on Hon Vincent Ekow Assafuah to ask the Question.

MINISTRY OF YOUTH DEVELOPMENT AND EMPOWERMENT

Measures to Address the Growth of “Red” Abuse

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah (NPP — Old Tafo): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment what specific measures the Ministry has instituted to address the growing “*wonim red*” trend among the youth, which many regard as a threat to discipline, morality and responsible citizenship in Ghana.

Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment (Mr George Opare Addo): Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Youth Development and Empowerment was created and mandated to formulate, coordinate the implementation, and monitor policies and programmes to promote youth development and empowerment in the country as the very first step towards addressing this major challenge.

Mr Speaker, in response to the increasing usage of drugs and substance abuse among young people, the Ministry, in collaboration with its Agency, National Youth Authority, launched the “RED Means Stop” campaign also known as “Wonim Red”,

as an initiative aimed at creating awareness on the negative effects of substance abuse on 26th March, 2025.

Mr Speaker, the Red Means Stop campaign aims to create a powerful youth-led advocacy movement through direct engagement, peer-to-peer outreach, and community mobilisation. Key objectives include recruiting and training youth advocates, organising high-impact events, deploying multi-channel campaigns, building a visible youth-driven movement, and fostering community partnerships.

The campaign has been successfully rolled out across all 16 regions of Ghana, reaching every district in the country. This comprehensive coverage ensures that youth in urban and rural areas, as well as students in various types of educational institutions, are exposed to consistent anti-drug messaging and support services.

Mr Speaker, recognising that meaningful behavioural change requires multi-stakeholder engagement, the National Youth Authority has established strategic partnerships with key institutions and organisations to amplify the reach and impact of the Red Means Stop campaign.

The Authority partnered with two (2) Traditional Leaders, namely King Tackie Teiko Tsuru II, Ga Mantse of the Ga Traditional Area, and Yaa-Naa Abubakari Mahama II, the Overlord of Dagbon, who were engaged to lend their support to the campaign, as some communities in these regions were identified as hot spot areas on Red.

The Authority also partnered with Bike-life Ghana, a prominent youth movement and motorcycle enthusiast community, to engage urban youth demographics through creative and culturally relevant platforms. This partnership has facilitated the integration of anti-drug messaging into youth culture and lifestyle events, making substance-free living aspirational among peer groups.

The Authority again collaborated with YFM (Y107.9 FM), one of Ghana's leading youth-focused radio stations, which has been instrumental in amplifying Red Means Stop messages through regular programming, interviews, call-in shows, and public service announcements. This media partnership has significantly expanded our reach among young audiences who actively consume youth-oriented content.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry, together with the National Youth Authority, actively participated in the High School Party in the Park event, a major gathering of second-cycle institutions. This platform provided direct access to thousands of young people, enabling peer-to-peer conversations, distribution of educational materials, Red Ambassador recruitment, and real-time engagement on substance abuse prevention. The event demonstrated the effectiveness of meeting youth in their social spaces with relevant, non-preachy advocacy messaging.

In a strategic move to enhance the campaign's appeal and credibility among youth, the National Youth Authority

appointed renowned Ghanaian musician Medikal as an official Red Means Stop ambassador. Medikal's significant influence among young Ghanaians, particularly through his music and social media presence, makes him an ideal advocate for substance-free living.

As a Red Means Stop ambassador, Medikal serves as a visible role model championing anti-drug messages through his artistic work, public appearances, and social media platforms. His involvement includes participating in school outreach events, featuring Red Means Stop themes in music videos and performances, engaging with young fans on substance abuse dangers, and supporting peer advocate training and mobilisation initiatives.

Mr Speaker, building on the momentum generated by the research that the Ministry conducted, campaign launch, strategic partnerships, and celebrity ambassadorship, the National Youth Authority has developed a comprehensive roadmap for intensifying interventions against the "wonim red" trend and broader substance abuse challenges.

Nationwide Billboard Campaign

The Objective is to create high-visibility public awareness across all 16 regions through strategic billboard placements that reinforce the Red Means Stop message in high-traffic areas.

The Billboards will be strategically positioned in the following high-visibility locations:

- Major highways and transport corridors.
- City centres and market areas.
- School zones and youth gathering points.
- Bus and taxi terminals.
- Sports stadiums and entertainment venues.

The billboard campaign will provide constant visual reinforcement of the Red Means Stop message, reaching millions of Ghanaians daily. This sustained public awareness will normalise conversations about substance abuse, reinforce peer norms against drug use, and remind youth and communities of the dangers associated with opioid and substance abuse.

Expanded Youth Advocate Mobilisation

The Authority plans to recruit and train 2,000+ Red ambassadors across all regions. These youth advocates will serve as peer counsellors, event organisers, and grassroots mobilisers in their respective schools and communities. Training programs will equip ambassadors with skills in peer-to-peer communication, event planning, digital advocacy, public speaking, and community mobilisation.

Event-Based Outreach Activities

The next phase includes conducting 500+ school outreach events annually, organising Red Means Stop rallies and

youth festivals in communities, executing concert tours featuring popular youth artists, hosting inter-school sports tournaments promoting substance-free athleticism, and conducting talent showcases in drama, poetry, dance, and art with substance abuse prevention themes and messaging.

Multi-Channel Campaign Amplification

Plans include intensifying social media campaigns on *Facebook*, *Instagram*, *Twitter(X)*, *TikTok*, and *WhatsApp*, producing and distributing television spots and documentary content, implementing weekly youth-focused radio programs on multiple stations, engaging additional influencers and celebrities as campaign ambassadors, and producing creative arts content, including music, drama, visual arts, and poetry competitions.

Institutional Partnerships and Policy Development

Future initiatives include strengthening collaboration with the Ghana Education Service, Ministry of Health, and Narcotic Control Commission, establishing Red Advocacy Clubs as permanent fixtures in second-cycle institutions, developing comprehensive substance abuse prevention policies for schools, creating referral systems connecting students to treatment and rehabilitation services, and engaging religious institutions, traditional authorities, and community leaders as anti-drug advocates.

Monitoring and Evaluation

The Authority will conduct periodic surveys to assess changes in youth attitudes and behaviours, track Red Ambassador recruitment and engagement levels, monitor social media reach and engagement metrics, collect testimonials and feedback from participants, document best practices and lessons learned, and generate regular reports on program activities and impact for continuous improvement.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, the Ministry and the National Youth Authority's comprehensive response to the "*wonim red*" trend and substance abuse crisis demonstrates a serious commitment to protecting Ghanaian youth.

6:05 p.m.

Through rigorous research, nationwide advocacy campaigns, strategic partnerships, celebrity ambassadorship, and planned intensified interventions, we are building a powerful movement against substance abuse.

The upcoming billboard campaign represents a critical next step in creating sustained public awareness and reinforcing anti-drug norms across all communities. Combined with expanded youth mobilisation, event-based outreach, multi-channel campaigns, and institutional partnerships, these interventions position Ghana to make significant progress in curbing substance abuse among our youth.

Success will require continued political will, adequate resource allocation, sustained stakeholder collaboration, and most importantly, the passionate engagement of young people themselves. The RED MEANS STOP movement is their movement, and they are leading the way to a drug-free Ghana.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry will continue to monitor and assess the impact of these interventions, review them when necessary, and explore other means to ensure that youth engaged in drug use are sent to the country's rehabilitation centres for proper care.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, to be fair with the Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment, I know this question was actually filed about six months ago, and with his Answer with respect to —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Your supplementary question.

Mr Assafuah: I am just laying a basis.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Show me by the rule where you have to lay a basis for a supplementary question. Please ask a supplementary question.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, I want to ask the Minister if he has resources to be

able to embark on the billboard campaign that he told us about.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Opare Addo: I did not hear him. Could he repeat his question?

Mr Assafuah: I am asking if the Ministry has the resources to be able to embark on the billboard campaign.

Mr Opare Addo: Mr Speaker, I do not believe any Ministry has enough resources to undertake all the projects that they want to do. But what we have been able to do is to engage some private sector players to support us in that campaign. For instance, when we were doing the research, we got a private sector person to fund it. The Government has made some allocations, but we believe that we will need more, and so we will mobilise the needed resources to embark on that campaign.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further supplementary question?

Mr Assafuah: So, in short, the Ministry does not have the resources to do that. My second question is that the Ministry seems to have relied heavily on the media campaign. Has the Ministry actually done physical engagement in all 261 districts across the country, because the media campaign may not be enough?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Opare Addo: Mr Speaker, within the last one year, the Ministry has conducted some research work in our major tertiary institutions and all our second-cycle schools across the country, and it is based on that data that has informed the strategy that we are deploying.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, your last supplementary question, if any.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, my last question is whether the Ministry has identified specific hotspot areas or high-risk areas where the Ministry thinks this issue is very prevalent, and for that matter, they have specific interventions to deal with those areas, especially in our communities and our schools.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Opare Addo: Mr Speaker, the answer is yes. That is why, for instance, in the Northern Region, we are working with the Yaa Naa because Tamale is one of the hotspots that we have identified. The Greater Accra Region is also one of the hotspots we have identified, and that is why we are working with the Ga Mantse on these initiatives.

Mr Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, since the Minister has done enough engagements, I would like to know his targets, what numbers he is looking at now, and what numbers we should expect that after the campaign it will reduce to, because he said he has been able to —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Opare Addo: Mr Speaker, it will be difficult to state what the numbers are. The problem we have with the drug peddlers is that people do not volunteer information easily. But from the data we have, from the research we conducted, especially within our tertiary institutions, we know what the numbers look like in terms of percentages. Our vision is that we want to reduce those numbers drastically. With the interventions we are doing, we intend to do another survey at the end of the year, and based on that, we will be able to measure. Now we have a baseline, and so when we finish the survey this year, based on the interventions we have done, we will be able to tell. That will give us a sense of direction as to what we will do next when we have that information.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Aidoo: I want to ask the Minister if there are any counselling services or rehabilitation programmes rolled out by the Ministry as part of this initiative.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Opare Addo: Mr Speaker, almost all our tertiary institutions have some counselling services in place. We have also engaged the Mental Health Authority to work with them in that respect. We have also engaged the private sector. What we have realised is that most of the referral facilities are

owned by the private sector, and so we have engaged them. The only problem is the cost of treatment. So, we are still in talks with them through the Mental Health Authority to see whether that cost can be reduced, but almost all our tertiary institutions have places for referral where they have some counselling services that are rendered to students who undergo such challenges.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, we will move to the Question numbered — Hon Members, we have a tall day.

Yes, Leadership?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I heard from the Minister and read from the Answers he provided that he is collaborating with two major stakeholders. That is the Ga Mantse and the Yaa Naa. I want the Minister to tell us the kind of collaboration, how, when, and what is happening with this collaboration so far.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Opare Addo: Mr Speaker, we identified that the Greater Accra Region is one of the hotspots where there is a lot of substance abuse, and we also identified that the Northern Region, Tamale to be specific, was another hotspot for substance abuse. We know the role traditional authorities play in our cultural settings. So, as a Ministry together with the National Youth Authority, we formally paid courtesy calls on these traditional authorities, shared with them what our findings are, and have asked

them to be at the forefront of the campaigns for us.

Mr Speaker, we have actually done engagements in Ga Mashie proper, where the Ministry and the National Youth Authority have gone in to engage under the auspices of the traditional authorities. So that is the kind of collaboration we are having with them. We have gone there, we have briefed them, and then they are supporting our fight against the drug menace.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I also captured a very comprehensive response to how they intend to provide visibility and also to ensure that they recruit and conduct 500-plus school outreach events. Is the Minister able to tell us the budget for this? Do we know what we are budgeted for this, and where the budget is coming from?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please ask a specific question.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I am asking the Minister that with the nationwide billboard campaign, expanded youth advocate mobilisation, event-based outreach activities, multi-channel campaign amplification, institutional partnership and policy development, monitoring and evaluation, how much are we spending on all of this?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please ask specific questions, so that the Minister can pick the answer and come and tell you. We are dealing with figures. Are you talking about figures?

Mr Shaib: Yes.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please kindly ask specific questions and the Minister will come here and provide the answer.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, respectfully, this question is specific. Unless you otherwise—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Question overruled.

Mr Shaib: Very well, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Ask another question if you have.

6:15 p.m.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, that is fine. I have another question. The Hon Minister also intends to engage a music artist Medikal (Mr Samuel Adu Frimpong). How did you engage Medikal? Is the Minister paying them or he is doing it on *pro bono* basis?

Mr Opare Addo: We have not paid any moneys to Medikal. We have engaged and we are in conversations with him. We have asked him to be the lead and then be a front for us in this respect. But what we are working on currently is to get some other artists to come on board, compose some music, and then put it out. So, when there is any cost associated with this, we will inform the House appropriately.

Thank you.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, is the Hon Minister saying that he will do that job before he will come and seek clearance as to how much he is paying?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your question is overruled. The answer is very clear. Hon Minister, you may get seated.

Mr Philip Fiifi Buckman: Mr Speaker, I would want to ask the Hon Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment which makes him the commander of the Ghana Youth—

Has the Hon Minister considered steps of prevention rather than solving this challenge with this recruitment? Has the Hon Minister considered ways of collaborating with other institutions in preventing this “red” coming into our country?

Mr Opare Addo: Yes, we have always advocated for prevention. So, a lot of the campaign we are running is targeted towards prevention. We have also engaged the various stakeholders, like the Narcotics Control Commission, the Mental Health Authority, and the Ministry of Health as to how best we can address this. We are also in talks with the Ministry of Education to see how best we can do a lot of advocacies in our schools to be able to prevent this menace.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, let us move to the Question numbered 352, standing in the name of Mr Abdul-Fatawu Alhassan, Member of Parliament for Yendi.

Completion of the Yendi Youth Resource Centre

Mr Abdul-Fatawu Alhassan (NDC — Yendi): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment the plans of the Government to complete the Yendi Youth Resource Centre which is also known as the Yendi Stadium.

Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment (Mr George Opare Addo): Mr Speaker, the Ministry inherited these eight uncompleted multi-purpose Youth Resource Centres (YRCs) in eight regions across the country. These projects were initiated by the National Youth Authority and commenced in 2018. They were designed to combine recreational facilities, attracting youth as a one-stop centre for youth congregation and development.

The primary objectives of the project were to enhance youth development by developing and sharpening their talents, providing Entrepreneurship Training, and encouraging the Youth to acquire life skills to make a valuable contribution to national development.

The Projects were to be undertaken in two phases (Phase I and Phase II), with the Phase I made up of spectator stands, football pitches, running tracks, tennis courts, handball & volleyball courts. The design also provided spaces under the stands for offices for youth development training, a Counselling centres, an ICT centre, a restaurant, and a youth-friendly health centre.

Phase II of the projects included the external fencing, inner perimeter fencing, Security gates, ticketing booths, floodlighting, provision of electricity transformer and generator, external works (pavements and lawns), and storm drains.

The following works were completed under the Phase I contract:

- Construction of a VIP Stand and 3 Spectator Stands
- Construction of a FIFA standard football pitch
- Construction of Running track sub-base
- Plumbing works
- Electrical wiring and fittings
- Construction of Tennis and Handball Courts

Regrettably, work on the Phase II contract of the project has experienced significant delays due to financial challenges, which have greatly impacted the project. Releases from the District Assemblies Common Funds (DACF), the main source of funding for the National Youth Authority, have stalled. The five percent (5 per cent) of the DACF, as instructed by the NYA Act 939, has varied with the NYA receiving less than 1 per cent of the DACF since the last quarter of 2023. This has greatly impacted the NYA's ability to proceed with the completion of the Youth

Resource Centres simultaneously across the country. The NYA is indebted to its contractors, forcing them to abandon the various sites.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry wishes to assure the House that Phase I of the project, which has been fully completed, will be put into use immediately.

Mr Speaker, discussions are currently ongoing between the Yendi Municipal Assembly and the NYA District Secretariat to begin allowing the youth in Yendi to start using the facility.

Again, efforts are made to impress upon the District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF) Secretariat to release funds to the Authority to commence Phase II.

Barring any unforeseen circumstances, phase II of the project is expected to be completed by the end of 2026 to make it fully functional.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry wishes to assure the Hon Member of Parliament that Phase I of the projects, which has been fully completed, will be put into use immediately.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry has intensified efforts to secure releases from the District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF) Secretariat funds to the NYA to enable the commencement and completion of Phase II of the project by the Authority.

The Ministry expects the Yendi Youth Resource Centre to be completed

by the end of 2026, to make it fully functional for the benefit of the youth within Yendi and its environs.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, this is a constituency-specific Question.

Let us move to Question number 648, standing in the name of Isaac Boamah-Nyarko, Member of Parliament for Effia.

Pending Salaries of 300 staff of YEA recruited in December 2024

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP — Effia): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment when the 300 staff recruited under the Youth Empowerment Agency (YEA) in December 2024 will begin receiving their salaries.

Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment (Mr George Opare Addo): Mr Speaker, the Youth Employment Agency (YEA) in 2024 recruited 300 staff and duly issued appointment letters.

Mr Speaker, upon assumption of office in January 2025, the new management conducted an internal audit as part of finalising the payment processes of the 300 new appointees. However, the audit revealed some anomalies in the recruitment processes leading to the suspension of the process of payment of salaries.

Mr Speaker, the audit revealed the following:

Inconsistent documentation —

- (a) The audit revealed that 50 appointees did not meet the 1-year criteria for regularisation in line with the management directives.
- (b) 30 of the appointees were unable to provide relevant certificates.
- (c) 13 of the appointees did not meet the minimum qualifications in the YEA scheme of service.

It was further observed that the dates of appointment letters preceded the official report from the Public Services Commission invalidating all the appointment letters to be used to process payment of salaries.

The audit also identified that the selection criteria for successful candidates is not available for review.

Another finding was missing interview documentation — interview score sheet and the attendance register for candidates were not available for review, making it impossible to verify whether the affected persons participated in the interview processes or not.

The audit, therefore, recommended to management annulment of the entire recruitment process and that a new recruitment exercise should be initiated to enable management to subject applicants to the prescribed processes and procedures for recruitment and appointments into the public service.

Mr Speaker, following the recommendations of the audit report, management decided to suspend the approved recruitment and salaries thereof as a result of the irregularities.

Thank you.

6:25 p.m.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, from the Minister's Response, he indicated that 50 appointees did not meet the one-year criteria; 30 were unable to provide relevant certificates, and 13 did not meet minimum qualification. If we put them together, it comes to about 93 people or persons that had issues.

Can the Hon Minister tell us why the rest of the 207 were not given the appointment letters since they did not find any anomaly with their documentation?

Mr Opare Addo: I did not say that the remaining did not have issues. I said that the audit also identified that the selection criteria for successful candidates were not available for review. Another finding was missing interview documentation. So, for all of them, we could not find any documentation for their interviews and even their attendance register was not there.

When we assumed office, they had not been even put on the payroll in the first place. So, they were not there in the first place for us to suspend them or not. We realised that appointment letters were hurriedly given to them but there was no documentation to substantiate

the employment that was given to them. Thank you.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, government is a continuum, so I believe the Minister and the Agency could have continued with those processes and given the appointment. But anyway, according to the Hon Minister, he said that despite the audit recommendations, management decided to suspend the approved recruitment and salaries thereof. My question to the Hon Minister is that did they communicate officially to the staff who were affected, since even post December, he knows that some had continuously worked for close to a year without salary payment? Did they officially communicate to those affected persons?

Mr George Opare Addo: Mr Speaker, I would have to check with the CEO and get back to this House in that respect.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to ask my third and final question. Mr Speaker, with regard to the response given by the Hon Minister, on the basis of this growing youth unemployment and the fact that these youths are his people—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I am beginning to have a problem with you. What is your final supplementary question?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: So, my question is that for the period that they worked and have not received salary, would the Hon Minister look at it and

make sure that, at least, the arrears of their salaries are paid?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: From what I have gathered, there is no record; that is what the Minister is saying. What record are they going to use to effect the payment? You have listened to the answer. Please ask another question.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Hon Minister, based on the annulment, whether he has plans—because they said that the audit recommendation was that they go through prescribing —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, are you asking a question or are you talking to yourself?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I am asking the Minister a question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, what is your question?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: My question is that when is the Minister going to provide another opportunity for these affected persons to get employed under the YEA programme?

Mr Opare Addo: We will be undertaking another recruitment exercise. When that time comes, we will duly inform the 300 to reapply and then we will subject them to the same interview processes. If they pass, we will employ them.

Mr Shaib: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I want to find out from the Hon

Minister, in his response, he said he based the annulment on an audit report. The same audit report is asking him to recruit. “The recruitment should be initiated to enable management to subject applicants to the prescribed processes and procedures and appointment given.”. Has he done so?

Mr Opare Addo: We are yet to undertake that process, but we will definitely undertake it this year. When that time comes, we will inform them.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, the same audit report that the Minister quoted from, also indicated that the suspension of approved recruitment, their salaries thereof should also not be paid. Do we know the numbers that we are talking about and how much is supposed to be paid?

Mr Opare Addo: I do not have that information readily available. I will provide it in the House if it is requested for.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That brings us to the end of Questions scheduled for the Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment. On your behalf, I thank the Minister for attending upon the House to respond to the said Questions.

We will then proceed to have the Questions for the Minister of State in charge of Government Communications. May I ask the Minister to take the designated seat.

Hon Minister, thank you for coming. I call on Hon Frank Annoh-Dompreh to pose the first Question.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, with deference to you and with your permission, I have the authority of Hon Frank Annoh-Dompreh to ask the Minister of State in charge of Government Communications this Question.

OFFICE OF GOVERNMENT COMMUNICATIONS

Full Details of Government Advisory Council and Cost to Taxpayer

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib *on behalf of Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh (NPP — Nsawam/Adoagyiri):* Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister of State in charge of Government Communications, the full details of the Government Advisory Council which was set up upon the invitation of the President to representatives of Civil Society Organisations (CSOs) in Ghana, and what this auxiliary body is costing the taxpayer.

Minister of State in charge of Government Communications (Mr Felix Kwakye Ofosu) (MP): Mr Speaker, let me clarify from the outset that the Governance Advisory Council has not yet been set up.

A Bill to establish the Council is currently before this House for consideration and passage.

The consideration and passage of the Bill by this House will offer scope for deliberations which will adequately address any enquiries and questions that may arise regarding the details, objectives, purpose and function of the

Council. Mr Speaker, having regard to the fact that the Council has not been set up yet, the issue of cost does not arise at this stage.

Mr Shaib: I want to find out from the Hon Minister if he has an idea when the council will be set up.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, resume your seat. You said a Bill is brought to Parliament to establish the council, so it is now in the domain of Parliament, not in the hands of the Minister. That is what the Minister said in his answer.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I heard that, but I also have a certain view that although Bills come to Parliament —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, in the event that Parliament does not pass the law, what happens?

Mr Shaib: Very well. I take a cue.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is the impulse of your question.

Total Cost of Committees Formed by the President and Sources of Funding

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah (NPP — Old Tafo): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister of State in charge of Government Communications the total cost of all committees formed by the President and his Ministers and the sources of funding since the expenditure was not included in the first-quarter Budget approved by Parliament.

6:35 p.m.

Mr F. K. Ofosu: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. The sponsor of the Question seeks information on the committees formed by the President and Ministers, the cost to the State, and how they were funded. Let me say that I speak for the President and his Office, and as such, I am only able to speak to what the President has done in relation to this Question. Though I am also the Minister for Government Communications, which means that I coordinate Government information dissemination, Questions on committees formed by Ministers are best answered by the relevant sector Ministers themselves, as my office has no hand in the formation of the committees spoken about.

However, on the specific issue of the committees formed by the President, I am able to report that the following committees have been formed by His Excellency the President:

- Preparatory Committee on Operation Recover All Loots, popularly called ORAL.
- Planning Committee for the National Economic Dialogue.
- Planning Committee for the National Forum on Education.
- Planning Committee for the Independence Day Celebration; and finally,
- The Constitution Review Committee.

Mr Speaker, in respect of the Preparatory Committee for Operation Recover All Loots, ORA, and the Planning Committee for the Independence Day Celebration, I can report that no money was spent on their work as members of the two committees did not take any per diems or allowances or any form of payments. Despite being appointed by the President, the Planning Committees for the National Economic Dialogue and National Education Forum worked under the auspices and in collaboration with the Ministries of Finance and Education, respectively.

Regarding the costs of the two fora, those were borne by the two Ministries. As I indicated early on, the Ministers for Finance and Education would be best placed to disclose the costs that they incurred in the process. The Constitution Review Committee was financed through the Office of the Chief of Staff. However, I must indicate that even though the committee has presented their reports, the process is not complete. There is a pending Committee on Implementation, which will be formed shortly. Once they are formed, they will carry on the processes to their logical conclusion, which includes bringing recommendations to this House for approval. It is when that has been done, and everything has been concluded that we will be in a position to compute the costs and make the same known to the Ghanaian public.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, on page 62 of the *Order Paper*, the advertised Answer is in paragraph 2. I read:

“When I received the question from the Hon Vincent Asafuah [sic], I wrote back to Parliament, through the Clerk, to seek clarity and specificity as I was being asked to answer questions for government organisations I do not speak for or do not work in.”

Mr Speaker, I have in my hand a *Facebook* post of the Hon Felix Kwakye Ofosu, which declares:

“Today I appear for the Government Accountability Series to answer all questions related to the work of the President, the Presidency and government in general.”

Is it the case that the Minister speaks for some selected Ministries at his own convenience, or he speaks for all the Ministries?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Your question overruled, ask another question.

The import of your question is the committees formed by His Excellency the President, the costs, and the source of funding are the three things in your Question. Read Standing Order 89.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, respectfully, I disagree with you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let us read Standing Order 89 together. You are

a lawyer, so I will be happy engaging you.

Mr Assafuah: When I stand here, I stand here on behalf of the people of Old Tafo.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But you are a lawyer, I will be engaging you. This is what Standing Order 89 says:

“(1) As soon as a Question is answered, any Member beginning with the Member who asked the Question may, without notice, ask a Supplementary Question for further clarification of any matter of fact on the answer but a Supplementary Question shall not introduce a matter not included in the original question.”

In the original question, is there any issue with *Facebook* posts included?

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, I so much agree with the Standing Orders. The basis or fulcrum of my question is paragraph 2 of his answer. Paragraph 2 of his answer states—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Look at the Order as a whole, “... but a Supplementary Question shall not introduce a matter not included in the original question.” That is the guideline. You may ask a question from the Answer, but it must flow from the original Question. In your original Question, you are asking for three things: the committees formed, the costs incurred, and the source of funding.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, sometimes you would respectfully have to also consider some of these conversations. My Colleague is a legal practitioner; whatever the answers are, his question was also based on some evidence that the Minister once upon a time made this Statement, and he referred to that by showing this House that this was what the Minister said in his *Facebook* post.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes. Let me ask you — because I will be comfortable engaging you as a lawyer. The Question is on committees formed, costs incurred on those committees, and the source of funding. This is what the Question is asking. Tell me whether this Question has anything to do with *Facebook*.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, the Minister responds to every matter that has to do with the Government. He is the Minister responsible for Government Communications.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I intend not to argue with you. The question is overruled.

Mr Shaib: You asked me a question, and I am answering you. Mr Speaker, to be fair, if the Minister wants to answer this question and he does not even have the information on the said question, he could have said to my Colleague, let me come back and furnish him with the rest. He is the Minister responsible for Government Communications.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, in asking questions, the rules

are not framed because the Minister has the capacity to answer the Question or not. Supplementary questions must not introduce any matter. Now, if you ask the question on three things: the committees formed by the President, the costs incurred by the President, and the source of funding, then, in asking a supplementary question, he is referring to a *Facebook* post. Are we being fair to ourselves? That is my basis for overruling the question, and I think I am justified.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, we are not saying that you do not have the powers to overrule. All we are saying is that these questions are within the remit of the Minister. Besides that, the question that my Colleague followed up with, which was his supplementary question, he only showed the *Facebook* post as evidence to say that the Minister cannot approbate and reprobate. That is all.

Mr Speaker, if we are not careful, we will start having issues with credibility as to when there are Questions you cannot — because the same Minister is also noted to have said something on Community-based Health Planning and Services (CHPS) compound. When he was confronted with same Question, he came back to say that —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are getting completely out of order. Hon Member, if you have another question, please ask.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, this is a House that you yourself —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, do you have any further questions? If you do not have any further questions—

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, I have three supplementary questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, please ask if you have a further question.

Mr Assafuah: My question to the Minister stems from his own answer, page 62 of the answer that has been advertised in the *Order Paper*. Which answer is to the effect,

“When I received the question from the Hon Vincent Asafuah [sic], I wrote back to Parliament, through the Clerk, to seek clarity and specificity as I was being asked to answer questions for government organisations I do not speak for or do not work in.”

My question to him is that— Mr Speaker, you need to protect me. The Minister cannot be evasive. I am saying that this is a *Facebook* post—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What is your supplementary question? You can ask the Minister whether he said that to Parliament or not.

6:45 p.m.

But so long as you are referring to issues of *Facebook*, probably, you can ask a specific Question based on the *Facebook* post by the Minister, and then the Minister will come and answer. But this cannot be by way of a supplementary question.

Hon Member, I think we do not have any further supplementary question. If any other Member has a supplementary question, they may do so.

Mr Assafuah: I mean, Ghanaians are watching. This is not fair. My second question to him is that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, kindly resume your seat.

Mr Assafuah: I have three questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I take offence from the expression that I am not being “fair”. Resume your seat.

Yes, Hon John Darko, if you have a supplementary question, you can ask.

Mr Assafuah: It is alright, I retract that, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon John Darko, if you have a supplementary question, you may ask.

Mr Assafuah: No, I have questions. I am saying that I retract that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, in the absence of any supplementary question, you are accordingly discharged. We thank you for attending upon the House and responding to Questions.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, you cannot be this unfair. We are seeing how unfair you are—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Question Time has ended.

Mr Assafuah: We are likely to disrespect you as well. We are Members of Parliament as you are. We have every responsibility to speak. Why, can we not speak? [*Uproar*] We have questions; can he not answer? We will disrespect you if you disrespect us. You cannot disrespect this Side of the House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your conduct is becoming disorderly. I can ask the Marshalls to walk you out if you continue.

Yes, Majority Leadership?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, we want to take the item numbered 19 at page 20 of the *Order Paper* for today, Security and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025, if it pleases you. We will take clause 1 to 4, pause and go back to the Legal Education Reform Bill, 2025.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the application is to take the item numbered 19.

Yes, Minority Leadership?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, we are not opposed to it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Members, Security and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025 at Consideration Stage.

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

Security and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Clause 1, Chairperson of the Committee.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, respectfully, we do not have copies. My Colleagues want to contribute, but there are no copies.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Was this Bill not distributed long ago? Yes, Clerks-at-the-Table, do you have enough copies?

Yes, clause 1.

Clause 1 — Composition of National Security Council.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee?

Chairperson of the Committee (Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlins): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Proposed amendment, *delete* subclause (2).

The reason being that in Article 83, the establishment of the National Security Council gives a bit of leverage in terms of three options of persons for the President to add to the sitting of National Security Council meetings. And in this Bill, what happens is that it ties the hands of the President to three specific persons. And the Committee was of the view that this would limit the

leeway around the invitation of members to be part of the National Security Council. Given that we cannot fully anticipate future threats or perceived national security risks, the Committee was of the view that we needed to *delete* this specific subclause to retain the original rendition.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the proposal is to *delete* subclause 1(2). Any further? Hon Members, I will put the Question.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 1 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Clause 2.

Clause 2 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 3 — Procedure at meetings of the Council.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairperson of the Committee?

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, proposed amendment, Headnote, *delete* “Procedure at”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the proposal is to *delete* “Procedure at” so that the Headnote will remain “Meetings of the Council”. I will put the Question on the proposed amendment to the Headnote.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon John Darko?

Mr John Darko: Mr Speaker, on clause 3, I propose that:

“A person invited to participate in the deliberations of the Council under subsection (2) shall not vote on a matter for decision before the Council, and shall take the oath of secrecy.”

Since this is a security matter, if the President invites somebody who is not a member of the Council to sit in the deliberation, I propose that before the person is admitted, the person takes and subscribe to the oath of secrecy.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Which clause are you talking about, Hon Member?

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, I am talking about subclause 3(3). It actually starts with subclause 3(2), that:

“The President may, acting in consultation... invite such other persons as the President considers necessary for any deliberations of the Council.”

So, my proposal is that those people who may be invited by the President will be required to take the oath of secrecy.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, what is your proposed amendment?

6:55 p.m.

Mr Darko: So, Mr Speaker, my proposed amendment is to add — so if you take 3(2),

“The President may, acting in consultation with the Council, invite such other persons as the President considers necessary for any deliberation of the Council, and such persons shall take the oath of secrecy before deliberation”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is there a provision in the law for members to take oath of secrecy?

Mr Darkko: Mr Speaker, I am saying that this is National Security Council and I am sure when the members are being constituted, they will be asked to take the oath of secrecy, or looking at the calibre of people, they probably would have taken the oath of secrecy anyways, but the law is asking the President to bring in people who are not members of the Council and I am saying that for the purposes of protecting our national security, those people who will be invited, should be asked to take the oath of secrecy.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we should be very careful asking a constitutional provision to be amended when it is repeated in a law. If you look at Article 83(3), it reads, “The President may, acting in consultation with the National Security Council, invite such persons as he considers necessary for any deliberations of the Council”. We are here making an Act of

Parliament which seeks to repeat a constitutional provision. So, if you are calling for amendment of that provision, then you are in effect amending the constitution through the back door. Because this is just a repetition of a constitutional provision.

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, with respect, I beg to differ on this, because if the framers wanted us to know that this is a constitutional provision, they would have stated so like they did for Section 1. In Section 1, they stated the constitutional provision but did not do that in Section 3. In my view, because you are a lawyer, you are just importing it in, that this is lifted from the constitution. If it was supposed to be lifted from the constitution, the drafter would have stated so. So, on this, I do not see it as something that is coming from the constitution.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Do you agree with me that this provision is the same as what I have read in the constitution?

Mr Darko: Of course, Mr Speaker, you have read the constitutional provision.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You can take your constitution and look at Article 83(3) and then you look at the provision in clause 3(2) and you will realise that it is verbatim. Being verbatim, the constitution is the supreme law of the land, above and beyond which no further law exists. The headnote of this particular constitutional provision is National Security Council. And now,

this particular provision is dealing with national security.

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, if that is the argument, then you see that the headnote of this one is not National Security Council. We have now deleted the procedure and the headnote of this one is Meeting of the Council. And unless you are telling me that the whole of section 3 is lifted from the constitution, then I can concede. But I do not think that the whole of section 3 is lifted from the constitution.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, I am not talking about the whole of the section 3. What I want you to understand is that the constitution being the supreme law of the land, if it states that the President may, acting in consultation with the National Security Council, invite such persons as he considers necessary for the deliberations of the Council, but the constitution does not tie it to those being invited to take oath and then we are making law by an Act of Parliament—We are saying that the President may, acting in consultation with the Council, invite such other persons as the President considers necessary for any deliberations of the Council. Will you not agree with me that by adding to this constitutional provision, we are amending? In other words, when this law is in conflict with the constitution, which one prevails? So that is why in drafting, we believe that you cannot be wrong using the constitutional language.

Mr Darko: Yes, Mr Speaker, let me just make my last point. Your point would be, in my view, valid if the

provision had made reference to the constitution. You understand? If the provision had made reference to the constitution, then you would be 100 per cent right. But as it stands now, you are the only one saying that it is being lifted this from the constitution. Here, it is just an Act of Parliament and we are definitely not seeking to amend any part of the constitution. So Mr Speaker, let us be careful. This is not the constitutional provision we are lifting. If it had made reference to the constitutional provision here, I would not have even made any case. But as it stands now, I believe that by adding the suggested addition, we are not definitely amending the constitutional provision. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will come to you. Let me hear them then I can come to you.

Yes?

Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, I believe that for sensitive meetings in this country, especially Cabinet, for instance, if new persons come in, they are asked to swear an oath of secrecy. I do not think there will be anything wrong if we can add such a clause in addition to the constitutional provision we are talking about so that we can protect the sanctity of the National Security.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: My problem is that when a provision is lifted from the constitution, you do the lifting as a whole. You know the process of amending the constitution is spelled out

in Article 289 and 290. That is a different process altogether. And two, the constitution is the supreme law of the land and any other law which is inconsistent to the constitution is null and void. Now, the constitution has a whole chapter, or a whole provision dealing with National Security Council.

Now, this particular provision is also dealing with National Security Council. Now, the constitution gives power to the President to invite any member that he deems fit to attend the meeting. Now, because this provision in the law is also dealing with the National Security Council meeting, the provision in the constitution, particularly in Article 83(3), is being lifted and placed in this particular law, for me, for ease of reference. Because if this is not in this law, the President has the constitutional power to do it anyway. Now, by the introduction of the amendment, what we will be having in this law will have a tie, different from what is stated in the constitution. So, clearly, I am seeing it as an amendment because if it is not seen as an amendment, when you put this law together, it is the constitution that prevails.

Mr Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, I believe that since you are concerned with the amendment, maybe you can add an additional amendment to this one so that what you are saying stands, and then the additional provision will be that the person who has been nominated by the President —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, do you have the constitution

with you? Maybe we are not reading the—If you put the provision in the constitution, Article 83(3), and then clause 3(2) together, you will realise that it is verbatim. It is just copied and pasted there. That is why I am saying that, any attempt to add—and in drafting, if you use a constitutional language, you do not add.

Yes, let me hear you, Hon James Agalga.

7:05 p.m.

Mr James Agalga: Mr Speaker, this matter does not even admit of any form of debate, because the clause is so clear. It reads, with your kind permission, composition of National Security Council. That is clause 1, and it says, “the National Security Council established by Article 83 of the constitution consists of —” so this is a direct lift from Article 83 and it goes on and on.

In fact, the wording is verbatim and it goes on. We have amended the procedure at meetings and the headnote is “Meetings of the Council”. So, Mr Speaker, you are right in stating that any attempt to introduce the amendment he is proposing would amount to an amendment of Article 83, which is entrenched.

Let us allow this to pass.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me hear from the Chairperson of the Committee.

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, just to add that if we look at the interpretation section of the Bill, it defines what council is, and council is the National Security Council. So please make reference, and we will find that, for brevity's sake, council is used in the Bill. The interpretation tells us what council means.

So the Hon Member was asking which council, and the interpretation speaks to that. So the council is the National Security Council.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, you have the floor.

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, with respect, I think that my Colleagues are missing the point because my Friend and Brother just walked in. My argument here has nothing to do with clause 1. My argument has to do with clause 3(2). After this, I will sit down and leave everything to the Speaker. What I am saying is that if we look at it, it says that

“The President may, acting in consultation with the Council, invite such other persons as the President considers necessary for any deliberations of the Council.”

So my issue is that those other persons who will be invited should be subjected to the oath of secrecy. You did not even address it. He has completely lost the plot. I am saying that if we can add the suggested amendment, it will protect the State. Mr Speaker disagrees and believes this is lifted from the Constitution. And so any addition will

amount to a constitutional amendment. But I am saying that if the framers wanted us to know this is from the Constitution, they would have stated it as they did for clause 1 of the Bill. That is the point I am making.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon John Darko, in drafting, when there is a need for cross-referencing, they do the cross-referencing. But in this particular case, the Constitution established a National Security Council with each composition having associated rights. This is not an issue of cross-referencing Article 83 of the Constitution, so they would have stated Article 83 of the Constitution. If you look at clauses 1, 2, and 3, you would realise that it is a repetition of the constitutional provision in Article 83. So this is not a matter of cross-referencing.

Mr Darko: Then, Mr Speaker, with respect, why did we amend the two? If 1, 2, and 3 are directly lifted from the Constitution, then why did she take the 2 out? And you agree that it should be taken out as well?

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, the deletion that was proposed by the Committee is to allow this Bill to be aligned with Article 83 of the Constitution, which is an entrenched section of the Constitution. So we just do not want to change what is there, where the President is given flexibility to select three people, now narrowed down to three specific people: Immigration, National Fire Service, and gender balance. So it is really just respecting what is in the parent document, which is the Constitution.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: In other words, if you look at the constitutional provision in Article 83, it does not have the two. That was the basis of deleting the two.

Yes, Hon Members, can I now put the Question? Yes.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, this begs the question. Where are the Ministers? The Minister and the Deputy Minister. This is a major security situation. They come with all deference to dump, and then move away. They should be contributors to this debate. And then, when it is critical to solicit their views on policy matters, we can go back to ask them. But as usual, they will come, leave it, and give it to the Chairpersons.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, what is your suggestion?

Hon Minority Leader, I will come to you. I am just asking him to offer the suggestion in the circumstances. So when you get up, he will not be able to respond.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, he was echoing the position of our Side, and I just wanted to pick it up from there to make the point clearer. If you grant me the leave.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but you know the rules pertaining to that.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: That he has to yield to me?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I just asked if you knew the rules pertaining to that.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, so you mean elucidation? You want to take me to the rules classroom when you and I learnt the rules together?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The rule says that it is when the Member—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you must not be too hard on the Leader.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, I am not being too hard.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: But you know I have learnt my rules.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but they say if the Member is ready—He is on the floor.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: So, elucidation; you want him to say it for the record?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, it is not elucidation. He was on the floor.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, invoke prudence and let us make progress. I beg you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So I am a man of the rules, and you are the man of prudence. Yes, Minority Leader, you have the floor.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Thank you, Mr Speaker. You are all we have.

We fight and reconcile. That is the beauty of it.

Mr Speaker, I remember you saying that in your days as a Ranking Member on the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs, there were times that you had to literally shepherd some Bills in this very House. It is true. I also know for a fact, your industry at winnowing, where you would always be with Hon Kyei-Mensah-Bonsu, the then Majority Leader. But there can be exceptions. This is becoming one too many.

Mr Speaker, the argument I followed on television prior to entry and upon entry, if you pay attention to what my senior at the Bar, Hon Agalga, and my Colleague John Darko were putting across, clearly you could see that there is a policy issue. So, you could come in with your experience and knowledge on drafting to guide us. But the heavy lifting should not be the Chairperson's responsibility. The Minister responsible for this Bill must find time and come to the Chamber of Parliament. He has a Deputy Minister. They must find time for the House of Parliament. They cannot introduce a Bill and when they are needed to give a guide on policy, they are nowhere to be found. That is not acceptable.

Mr Speaker, this is an important legislation. Where is the Minister? We also dealt with the new Bill on Legal Education Reform for our young student lawyers. After the first effort by the Attorney-General, we have not seen him again. *[Interruption]* Hon Doyoe, with respect, I am careful with my choice of

words. I said, after his first efforts. We have been recording him absent upon absent. It gets to a point where partisanship cannot save a situation. It is not about the National Democratic Congress (NDC) or the New Patriotic Party (NPP) or maybe the Speaker having to manage it on your behalf.

7:15 p.m.

If they do not have time for the House of Parliament, they should not introduce their Bill. What is the time? There is a Minister and there is a Deputy Minister; one of them should at least be here.

Mr Speaker, nothing can save the situation. I am making a plea to the available Leader that he should make efforts to call the Minister responsible for National Security to come in, because there are serious amendments.

Mr Speaker, we have filed copious amendments. Some have gone into the *Order Paper*, and the *Order Paper Addendum* is also coming. Our Side is committed to doing Parliamentary Business. There are a lot of amendments. It is not going to be Business as usual and we need him here to answer questions and to debate on what will go into the Legislation.

Mr Speaker will not do any heavy lifting for anybody. You have been doing the heavy lifting for them this evening. They should come and do their work. That is what we are saying. It is not a party matter. It is not a matter of

NPP or NDC; it is about the country. They should stop it. *[Interruption]* Mr Speaker, Dr Norgbey is just a law student. So please, if he wants to rebut me, he should rise, catch your eye and speak. I do not entertain this noise — *[Interruption]*— Yes, then he should listen to me in silence.

Mr Speaker, I will rest my case, but there should be no excuses. Let the Minister come.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, we have taken the advice from the Minority Leader in good faith. I have reached out to the Minister and he is on his way, so we can proceed and the Minister will join us. *[Interruption]* We are now dealing with the Security and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025, so I have called the Minister and he will join us.

So Mr Speaker, we can make headway.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but it is good that the Sector Ministers are here to contribute to the process, but I would maintain that the power to make law is vested in the Parliament of the Republic of Ghana without any recourse to a Minister.

So, when a Bill is introduced in this House, it becomes a *bona fide* responsibility of Parliament until it is passed by the House. Article 93(2) is very clear so, we should be careful not to set a bad precedent that, because a Minister is not here, we should not proceed to do a consideration of a Bill. We will be causing harm to

ourselves contrary to the power given us by Article 93(2).

So, Hon Members, let us make progress.

Hon Members, any proposed amendment to clause 3?

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 3 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 4 — Functions of the Council.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee?

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, we are proposing that paragraph (a), line 2, *delete* “the country” and *insert* “Ghana.”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The proposed amendment is for the consideration of the House.

Hon Members, I will put the Question in the absence of any further amendment.

Yes?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I want some assistance from Hon Agalga. Earlier, he was referring to some verbatim lifting of a constitutional provision in respect of the discussion under Clause 3. Upon a careful reading of this clause, I note that the functions have been left open. In other words, what

seem to have been listed are indicative but not conclusive. So, the drafting language used here, “the functions of the Council in accordance with Article 84 of the Constitution include...”, then it gives a listing from (a) to (d). I would want to know from my Colleagues, Article 84, if we may turn to it, because he said “In accordance with 84.”

Mr Speaker, is it the case that this one was also lifted verbatim from Article 84, because going through the clause 4(b), it is not too clear. So, they may have to read again and then be double sure. If they think they are double sure, we may proceed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Are you talking in respect of the proposed amendment, “Ghana” instead of “country”?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: No, Mr Speaker, the Constitution refers to Ghana and I am saying that they should have a look at clause 4(b) again.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So then allow me, if you agree with the proposed amendment, to put the Question on the proposed amendment because I thought your amendment is to the proposed amendment.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, before we go to the clause 4(b)—

Very well.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, there is a further amendment to Clause 4, which is consequential.

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, just to clarify —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Move the amendment in the item numbered 19(iv).

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: The amendment proposed, paragraph (b), line 2, *delete* “the country” and *insert* “Ghana”, and in lines 2 and 3, *delete* “domestic and foreign security” and *insert* “domestic, foreign and security.”

Mr Speaker, all these amendments seek to do is to align the Bill perfectly with what is in the Constitution. So that it is a proper lifting from the Constitution to the Bill, that is why, where it says the country, we have replaced it with Ghana.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, it is for the consideration of the House. You have heard the rationale behind.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Yes, a further consequential amendment to clause 4, item number 19(v).

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, here again, it is for paragraph (c), lines 2, *delete* “the country” and *insert* “Ghana”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is a consequential amendment.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Now to entire the clause 4, we can then revert to the Minority Leader.

Mr Speaker, I think my respected Colleague, the Chair of the Committee, has done the needful on the (b). So, no further concerns.

Clause 4 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

7:25 p.m.

Clause 5 — Committees of the Council.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, the agreement was to end at clause 4. So, we will bring the Security and Intelligence Agency Bill, 2025, to an end for today, and take the Legal Education Reform Bill, 2025.

Thank you very much.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, my position has not changed. He said the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice was on his way. I do not know what he meant by he was on his way. He has not engaged our Side on—*[Interruption]*—Please, they have

briefed me. He has not engaged, so it is not a matter of saying I was not here. He should not use this excuse that I was not here to divide us. We always engage each other.

Mr Speaker, I would suggest that if Government does not have any more Business to be done while waiting for the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice, then we should adjourn the House. Tomorrow is very packed. Tomorrow, we have the Motion on these Ghana Gold Board losses to be taken, there is a public lecture and there are other matters. The policy that the Minister for Finance introduced, that was referred to the Finance Committee, that the Hon Majority Leader wants a Report taken tomorrow; so, tomorrow is a very packed day. Meanwhile, on Friday, we are supposed to prepare to receive the President, expecting that he would announce policies to increase the cocoa producer price back to its original state. That is our expectation as a Minority. Mr Speaker, these are very critical matters. Besides, they have many empty seats on their Side. If count them, they are just about 22.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, hold it. We have come to the end of the Consideration Stage of the Securities and Intelligence Bill, 2025 for today.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I am inclined to agree with the Hon Minority Leader. I was expecting that he would allow us to do about three clauses. But the way he put it, I have no other option than to agree with him. Mr

Speaker, we are in your hands. We have done more than five hours. Tomorrow, we can start by 10:00 a.m. and close early and leave this place for the security people to do the arrangements.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the available Leader leading Government Business says that there is nothing more to be done and that we are in your hands. We agree with him that indeed we are in your hands. We need to go rest and prepare for tomorrow. Tomorrow is a long day, a very long day.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, you said you are in my hands.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, relax. Mr Speaker do not miss mischief. Now you are our boss. I am saying that the Leadership of this House is in agreement that there should be an adjournment. Let me put it in an unfiltered language. That is the agreement between the two of us.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, I thought you are in my hands because we

have done in excess of five hours. So, I am speaking in respect—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well. Mr Speaker, I know you. Sometimes you can give an uppercut. When you announce that “you are in my hands”, I know what you can do thereafter.

Mr Speaker, it is not me Kwamena saying that we are in your hands. The two of us, Majority and Minority, are in agreement that this House be adjourned. However, as a matter of procedure, since we have gone beyond five hours, it is therefore your *bona fide*. Your prerogative to declare the House to stand adjourned. That is all.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is true we have sat in excess of five hours. Therefore, I stand on Standing Order 56(2) to adjourn the House.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 7:34 p.m. till Thursday, 26th February, 2026, at 10:00 a.m.

Editor's Note

This *Official Report* was adopted by the House on 5th March, 2026.